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ERRORS FOUND

NTA announces re-test for 3 papers of UGC-NET in Sept

MPPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, August 16

The National Testing Agency (NTA) will re-conduct the UGC-NET June 2026 examinations for English, Commerce and Sociology after a review found errors in the question papers.

The English paper will be held on September 9 from 9 am to noon in Shift 1, followed by Commerce from 3 pm to 6 pm in Shift 2. Sociology will be conducted on September 10 from 9 am to noon in Shift 1. No additional examination fee will be charged.

The NTA conducted the June examination from June 22 to 30 across 87 subjects for Junior Research Fellowship (JRF), eligibility for Assistant Professor and admission to PhD programmes. It said complaints **CONTINUED ON P4**

THOUSANDS REMAIN DISPLACED

Rescuers dig through rubble after Indonesia quake kills 51

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Ruteng (Indonesia), August 16

Rescue teams in eastern Indonesia recovered four more bodies Sunday after a magnitude-7.7 earthquake struck the day before, bringing the death toll to 51, authorities said. Thousands have been displaced.

The US Geological Survey said the powerful earthquake hit eastern Indonesia's Flores region at a depth of 10 kilometres (6 miles) at 5:58 am local time. Residents fled in panic as tsunami warnings were issued and later lifted. At least 235 aftershocks followed, according to Indonesia's meteorological agency.

Rescuers on Sunday dug



A man near a building collapsed due to earthquake AP/PTI

through debris looking for people feared buried beneath landslides triggered by the quake across six regencies on

- ### HIGHLIGHTS
- » USGS said the earthquake struck Flores at a depth of 10 kilometres
 - » The quake hit at 5:58 am local time, triggering widespread panic
 - » Tsunami warnings were issued after the quake but later lifted
 - » Indonesia's meteorological agency recorded at least 235 aftershocks following the earthquake
 - » Rescuers searched debris for victims buried beneath landslides across six Flores regencies
- Flores, a predominantly Catholic island in **CONTINUED ON P4**

Former TMC MLA

Asish Banerjee found hanging at party office

Suwendu assures thorough probe, Mamata cites 'pressure' as cause

AGNIHOTRI GUPTA
Kolkata, August 16



Former Trinamool Congress (TMC) MLA and West Bengal Assembly Deputy Speaker Asish Banerjee was found hanging at a TMC party office in Rampurhat, Birbhum, on Sunday morning while police recovered a purported suicide note and sent the body for autopsy.

Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari expressed grief and said the circumstances surrounding Banerjee's death would be investigated, including whether he faced any threat or pressure. He said Banerjee had maintained a clean image and dignity **CONTINUED ON P4**

CLOSER LOOK

- » The incident occurred at a TMC office in Rampurhat, Birbhum, on Sunday morning
- » Police recover a purported suicide note
- » Banerjee's wife alleged that repeated accusations and humiliation contributed to his death

Briefs

Vimal Elaichi ad: FDA notice to SRK, Ajay, Tiger

Mumbai: The Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) has issued a show-cause notice to actors Shah Rukh Khan, Ajay Devgn and Tiger Shroff over their participation in an advertisement for Vimal Elaichi, saying the campaign prima facie amounts to the indirect or surrogate promotion of prohibited pan masala and tobacco-related products.

The notice, issued by the FDA's Greater Mumbai division on August 11, identifies the three actors as brand endorsers and gives them 15 days from the date of **CONTINUED ON P4**

J'khand govt invites students for fresh talks

Ranchi: The Jharkhand government has invited students protesting alleged irregularities in recruitment examinations for talks on August 17 at 2 pm, an official said Sunday. The decision followed a meeting between the Sub-Divisional Officer, ADM Law and Order and students at Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium, the protest site. The 'JPSC-JSSC Reforms Manch' accepted the proposal, with talks to be held at the State Guest House in the presence of a legal advisor. Leader Ravindra Paswan said the students remain firm on demands for a CBI probe and cancellation of the JSSC-CGL examination. Six earlier rounds failed to resolve the issue. The protest entered its 23rd day Sunday. **SEE P6**

NLSIU students, alumni oppose CJI, BCI chairman attending convocation

MPPOST BUREAU
Bengaluru, August 16

Students and alumni of the National Law School of India University (NLSIU) have opposed Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Bar Council of India (BCI) Chairman Manan Kumar Mishra attending the convocation.

In a statement dated August 15, they criticised the BCI's withdrawn order directing state bar councils not to enrol NALSAR

University of Law's 2026 graduates as advocates over objections to a visit by the CJI.

The statement was signed by 165 graduating students of the Class of 2026, 409 current students and 128 alumni. They said the BCI's decision to close proceedings against NALSAR did not remove the responsibility of the body or its chairman for initiating what they described as unconstitutional and illegal pro-

ceedings against students and faculty.

The group said the BCI had acknowledged the arbitrary and illegal nature of its actions after withdrawing the enrolment ban and inquiry order. It demanded an unconditional apology to the NALSAR community, saying the action could have a chilling effect on free speech and create fear of **CONTINUED ON P4**

Shah targets Sonia over 'Vande Mataram' row, demands apology

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Jaipur, August 16

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday accused the Congress of disrespecting Vande Mataram and demanded an apology from the party over an alleged attempt to stop its rendition during the Independence Day programme at the Congress headquarters.

Addressing the 'Atal Gaurav Smriti Samaroh' in Chittorgarh, Shah alleged that Congress leader

Sonia Gandhi asked the party president to stop the national song while it was being sung. "Sonia ji, 140 crore people are watching you. This sin you have committed will never be forgiven by the people of this country," he said.

Shah also asked the Congress to apologise to the people and to Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay, who wrote Vande Mataram. He said thousands of people had faced bullets, lathis and **CONTINUED ON P4**

Rahman's India visit hangs on extradition of Sheikh Hasina

MPPOST BUREAU
Dhaka, August 16

Bangladesh on Sunday linked the proposed visit of Prime Minister Tarique Rahman to New Delhi with India's response to Dhaka's extradition requests for former prime minister Sheikh Hasina and other fugitives, adding uncertainty to Rahman's possible participation in events around the BRICS Summit on September 12-13. **CONTINUED ON P4**

IMD FORECASTS HEAVY RAIN ACROSS INDIA

States brace for more heavy rain as monsoon death toll crosses 440

MPPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, August 16

India remained on high alert as an active monsoon brought heavy rain, flash floods, landslides and cloudbursts across several states, with the India Meteorological Department (IMD) forecasting more widespread rainfall in the coming days. More than 440 people have died during the ongoing monsoon season across badly affected areas including Assam, Himachal Pradesh, Maharashtra, Jammu and



Kashmir and Kerala, while hundreds of thousands have been displaced and large stretches of essential infrastructure damaged.

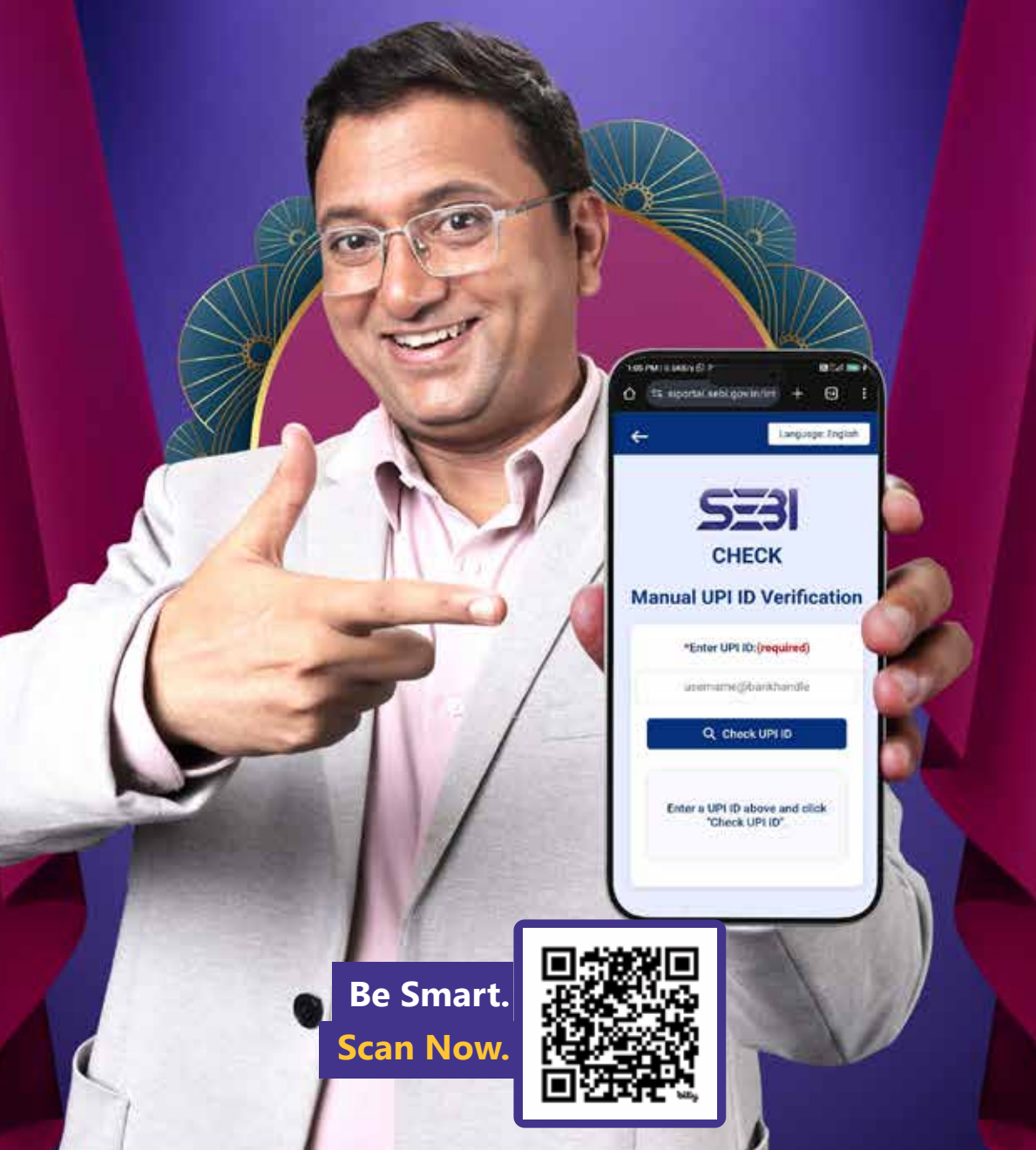
The weather office has forecast fairly widespread to widespread rain over Odisha, West Bengal, Jharkhand **CONTINUED ON P4**



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One death, many voices

Sanitation worker stabbed to death, colleagues protest

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 16

A 27-year-old MCD sanitation worker was allegedly stabbed to death in east Delhi's Kalyanpuri area, following which several of his colleagues staged a protest demanding the immediate arrest of the accused and compensation for his family.

The deceased has been identified as Anil.

According to the police, Anil was attacked with a knife and sustained serious injuries. He was rushed to a hospital where doctors declared him dead.

Police have sent the body for post-mortem and launched an investigation into the incident. CCTV footage from the area is being examined to identify the attacker. The purported CCTV footage of the incident has also gone viral on social media platforms.

In the purported footage, a man wearing a yellow



KALYANPURI KILLING

- » According to the police, Anil was attacked with a knife and sustained serious injuries. He was rushed to a hospital where doctors declared him dead
- » CCTV footage from the area is being examined to identify the attacker. The purported CCTV footage of the incident has also gone viral on social media platforms

T-shirt can be seen waiting at a distance while Anil was working. The man then appears to remove a sharp-edged object concealed at his back under his T-shirt before approaching Anil. After a few seconds of

what appears to be a verbal spat between the two, the man is allegedly seen stabbing Anil in the stomach in broad daylight.

The footage purportedly shows several passersby and a motorcyclist stopping

near the spot, but no one appearing to come forward to help the injured worker.

The accused then allegedly flees the spot after the attack. Anil is subsequently seen walking towards another location while trying to hold his stomach, seemingly at the place where he had sustained the stab wounds. He later collapsed and lay motionless on the ground.

Police have not yet publicly confirmed the authenticity of the viral footage and are examining CCTV recordings procured from the area as part of the investigation.

Anil's family members alleged that they initially received a call from the police informing them that he had met with an accident. When they reached the spot, they came to know that he had actually been stabbed.

The family claimed that Anil was called from behind before being attacked.

Over 500-km chase ends in two arrests

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 16

A 550-km interstate hunt led to the arrest of two men from Uttarakhand in connection with the killing of a 27-year-old man in northwest Delhi's Lal Bagh area, police said on Sunday.

Accused Aman alias Mulla (26) and Anuj alias Moni (20) were apprehended from a spot near Chappar Toll Naka while they were travelling in a rented car.

Officials said Anuj was also wanted in another murder case registered at the Jahangirpuri police station. The rented car and two mobile phones were seized from their possession.

"The incident took place on August 12 in the Lal Bagh jhuggi area of Azadpur, where police received PCR calls regarding a stabbing and firing. The injured man was rushed to the Babu Jagjivan Ram Memorial (BJRM) Hospital, where doctors declared him dead," a senior police officer said.

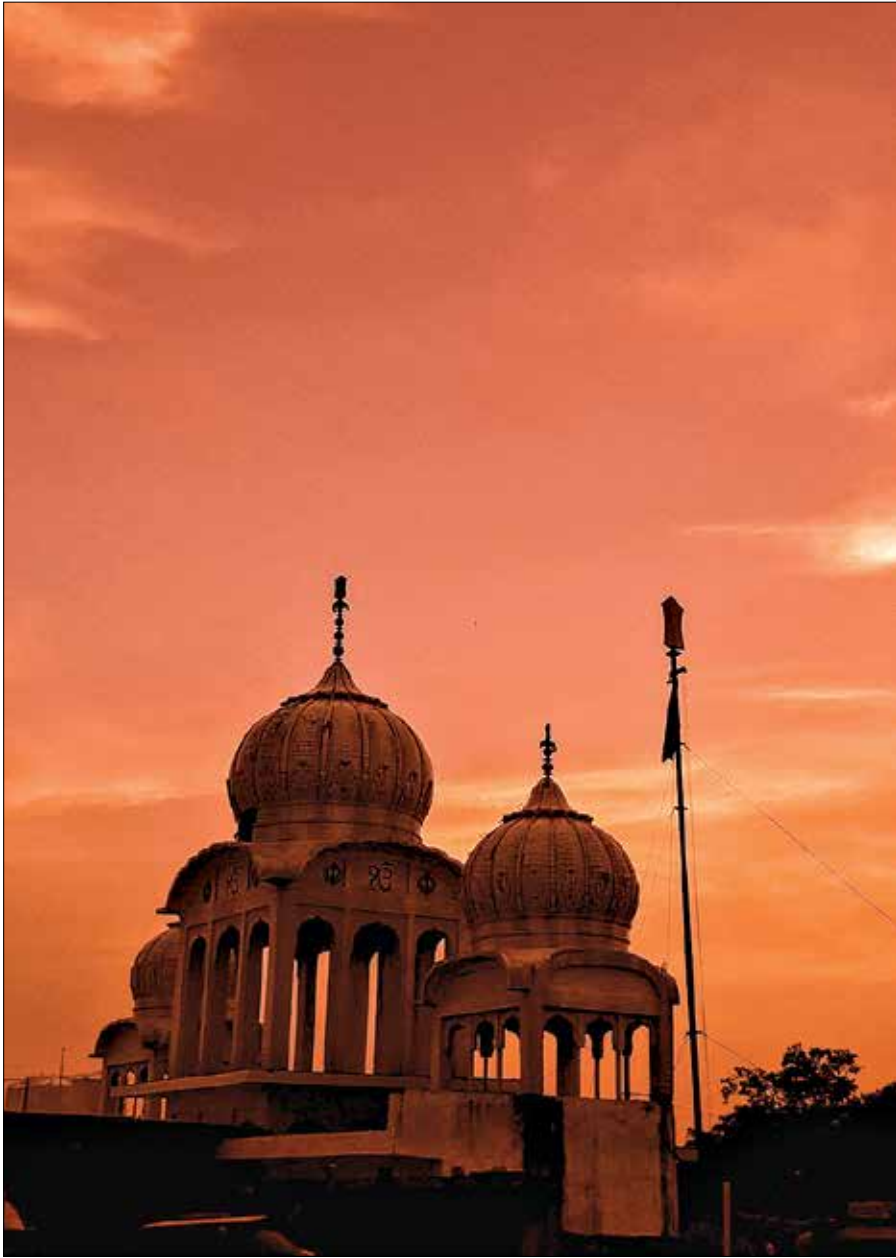
According to police, the victim had suffered firearm injuries, with entry and exit wounds in the abdomen and back, besides a stab injury on his back.

An eyewitness told police that he and the victim were near his house that night. Around 11:30 pm, they went to a shop where they encountered Aman and another person.

An altercation broke out between the victim and the accused, following which Aman and his associate allegedly threatened the two men before leaving the spot. The accused allegedly returned when the victim and the eyewitness were heading back to their locality and opened fire. While the eyewitness managed to escape, the victim sustained gunshot as well as stab injuries, the officer said.

A case was registered at the Adarsh Nagar police station, a team formed and an investigation launched.

GURUGRAM'S SUNSET GLOW



Orange hue covers the skyline during sunset, in Gurugram, on Sunday

Delhi woman raped twice by man she met on social media

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 16

A 22-year-old makeup artist was allegedly raped twice here by a man she befriended on social media after being drugged, police sources said on Sunday.

The woman also alleged that the man threatened to kill her when she resisted, the police sources said.

According to the complaint lodged by the woman, she met the accused through social

media last year. He introduced himself as a makeup artist and later called her to a hotel in northwest Delhi in July on the pretext of introducing her to people for business, a source said.

The woman claimed that the accused served her a cold drink laced with sedatives and raped her after she fell unconscious. The accused later promised to marry her and persuaded her not to approach police, the complainant alleged.

On August 8, the accused

allegedly took her to a hotel in GTB Nagar and raped her again. He also threatened her with dire consequences when she tried to resist him, the complaint stated. She was taken to Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital after her condition deteriorated, the source said.

An FIR has been registered in the matter and police are searching for the accused. CCTV footage and the entry register of the hotel have been seized, the source said.

Delhi airport eyes 125-mn capacity

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 16

Delhi airport plans to increase its annual passenger handling capacity to 125 million from the current level of 106 million under the proposed ten-year master plan, according to a source.

As part of the expansion under the master plan, DIAL also proposes to build Pier E at Terminal 3 (T3) with a capacity of 10 million by April 2030.

For now, no decision has been firmed up on having Terminal 4 or building the Automatic Passenger Mover (APM).

The Indira Gandhi International Airport (IGIA) in the national capital is operated by the Delhi International Airport Ltd (DIAL).

IGIA, also the country's biggest airport, has three terminals -- T1, T2 and T3 -- and international flight operations are only from T3.

The source told PTI that the master plan for 10 years till 2036 will be finalised after consultations with the stakeholders.

In the first phase, the proposal is to increase the annual passenger handling

capacity to 116 million by April 2030. The capacity will be further raised to 125 million by 2032, the source said.

At present, the airport has an annual passenger handling capacity of 106 million spread across the three terminals. The capacity is 42 million, 14 million and 50 million at T1, T2 and T3, respectively.

At T3, there is domestic capacity of 19 million and international capacity of 31 million.

Currently, T3 has four piers -- Pier A and B for international operations while C and D are for domestic operations. Pier C has now been converted for international operations.

Pier E is to be constructed at T3 by April 2030.

Generally, a pier at an airport is a long and narrow structure or transfer facility from the main terminal building and allows passengers to use aerobridges to enter an aircraft.

While there are no immediate plans, a 7.5-kilometre right of way will be earmarked for the APM (Automated People Mover) system in the master plan, the source said.

Briefs

Man stabbed to death

NEW DELHI: A 30-year-old man was allegedly stabbed to death in southeast Delhi's Okhla area, following which police detained one person and rounded up several suspects for questioning, an officer said on Sunday. The incident took place at around 10.15 pm on Saturday near the ESIC Hospital bus stand on Maa Anandmayee Marg in Okhla Phase-I, he said. The victim, identified as Raju, a resident of Mazdoor Kalyan Camp in Okhla Phase-I, was assaulted with a sharp-edged weapon, police said.

Delhi Sultanate paper dropped

NEW DELHI: The University of Delhi has dropped its long-running paper, "The Delhi Sultanate: Structures of Authority in Medieval North India (13th-14th Centuries)," from the newly notified postgraduate History syllabus. Several other papers, including those on North India, gender in early India, ancient political structures and religion, have also been omitted. Of 38 proposed Discipline Specific Elective papers, 16 were included in the Semester III syllabus will be notified.

Girl, 9, reunited with parents

NEW DELHI: A nine-year-old girl who was found abandoned in northeast Delhi's Sonia Vihar area was reunited with her parents after police traced her mother working as help at a police station, an official said on Sunday. The girl was found alone in the area by personnel of Sonia Vihar police station, following which the police team interacted with her to ascertain her identity.

Manjha cuts short young life

DIPIKA KIROLA
Ghaziabad, August 16

A 25-year-old delivery worker from Bihar died after a sharp Chinese manjha allegedly got entangled around his neck while he was riding a motorcycle on NH-9 with a friend on Saturday evening. The incident took place in the Kaushambi police station area as the two were travelling from Noida towards Ghazi- pur in Delhi.

The deceased, Raviraj, was a native of Khagaria in Bihar and lived in rented accommodation in Behlam- pur, Sector 63, Noida. He worked as an online delivery worker.

According to police, Raviraj was riding the motorcycle while his friend Naresh was seated behind him. The two had travelled from Noida and entered NH-9 from the Sector 43 cut. Near the highway the manjha suddenly became



entangled around Raviraj's neck. The motorcycle was moving at speed when the sharp string caused a deep cut to his neck. Raviraj began bleeding heavily, his friend managed to control the motorcycle and seek help.

A video of the aftermath of the incident has also surfaced online. The disturbing footage shows Raviraj on the highway after sustaining the injury, while his friend and other people gathered around him and tried to provide assistance. Peo-

ple can be seen attempting to support his injured neck and control the heavy bleeding. A cloth was tied around his neck in an effort to stem the bleeding until police and medical help arrived. Kaushambi police rushed Raviraj to Max Hospital in Vaishali where doctors declared him dead after examination. ACP Indrapuram Suryabali Maurya also reached the hospital after being informed about the incident.

Doctors that Raviraj had suffered a wound around 5cm deep on his neck and that the injury had also damaged the underlying bone. His family later took the body to Noida and reportedly declined a post-mortem examination. "The incident is being investigated. We are also trying to ascertain the source of the Chinese manjha involved in the incident. Further action will be taken based on the findings," Maurya said.

When marriage turns murderous

Six spousal homicides in July, twice last year's toll, expose troubling pattern

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE
New Delhi, August 16

A rising pattern of spousal murders has caused a number of cases of spousal homicide in Delhi as of late, with family disputes, illicit affairs, and other issues acting as potential catalysts for such violent acts.

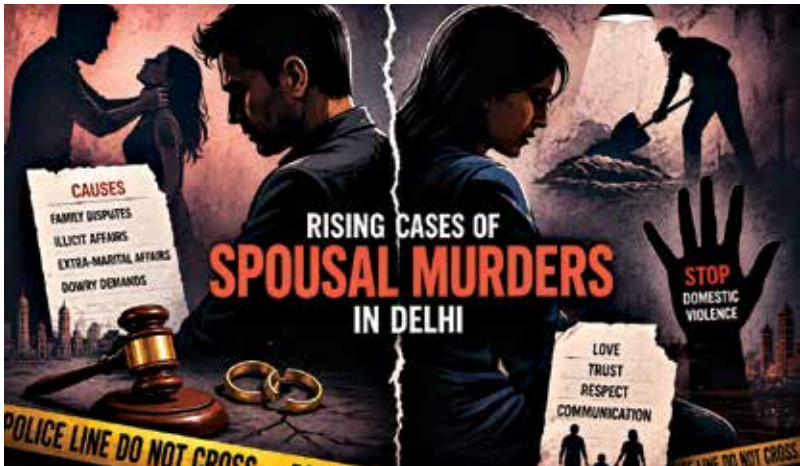
It has also fueled speculation that rising rates of interpersonal violence have resulted in changing ideas about marriage.

Delhi has seen a number of spousal homicides this August, with one of the most bizarre ones occurring recently.

A 53-year-old allegedly strangled his 50-year-old wife and buried her body after watching the crime film Staircase.

Another case which occurred recently involved a 45-year-old woman, who drugged her 55-year-old husband with sleeping pills before beating and electrocuting him in his presence, alongside her boyfriend. A 40-year-old allegedly throttled his wife to death in a similar case in Rohini.

The incidents come as Delhi has seen a total of six cases of spousal homicide this July, 2026, as compared



to three in both July 2025 and July 2024.

While one of the victims last year was a man and the rest were women, this year, out of the six, one was a man, with the rest being women, with the causes varying between illicit affairs and family disputes.

Similarly, in 2025, all three victims were men, with the reasons varying between family disputes, an extra-marital affair, and an illicit relationship.

In 2024, there were three female victims, with two of them being caused due to family disputes and one due to dowry.

A clinical psychologist, asked about spousal kill-

ings, opined that unless one of the partners is possessive, it does not occur out of thin air. Increased jealousy, monitoring, isolation, limiting finances, and viewing the partner as their own personal property leads to a point where the abuser feels entitled to the victim's body.

She further notes that non-fatal strangulation is potentially one of the most damaging warning signs of an impending spousal homicide.

"When it comes to imminent spousal homicide, separation or filing for divorce is the most dangerous time for the relationship as well as the potential victim.

KEY POINTS

- » Delhi has seen a number of spousal homicides this August, with one of the most bizarre ones occurring recently
- » A 53-year-old allegedly strangled his 50-year-old wife and buried her body after watching the crime film Staircase
- » Another case which occurred recently involved a 45-year-old woman, who drugged her 55-year-old husband with sleeping pills before beating and electrocuting him in his presence, alongside her boyfriend

Financial instability, infidelity, and disputes over children are some of the crucial catalysts of spousal homicide as they pose as direct threats to an abuser's sense of control," Dr. Deepmala Chauhan, a psychologist said.

Further, commenting on how authorities usually approach such cases, the psychologist noted that the issue has been wrongly approached as a series of standalone incidents rather than a pattern of coercive control.

Police, judiciary, and mental health professionals need to collaborate more effectively in order to establish long-term patterns of

abuse. "The man of a couple has to stand up for his woman to stop dowry. It is their duty. A family has given her to him, so why would they want more?" said a 63-year-old married woman. "It is also illegal. Even till today, people see it as normal but it is not," she added.

"A woman and a man come together into one house and share everything that they have when they decide to get married. For as long as her man lives, his wife is his family. She holds the same amount of authority over the joint property, as he does," said a 73-year-old married man.

Atal Canteens hit century

Needy students can access affordable, nutritious food: CM

AIMAN FATIMA
New Delhi, August 16

Marking the death anniversary of former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee, the Delhi government on Sunday said they achieved their target of opening 100 Atal Canteens across the city, with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announcing that the subsidised meal scheme will now also cater to university students. Former Vice President M. Venkaiah Naidu inaugurated 25 new canteens, taking the total to 100.

Calling the initiative a tribute to Vajpayee's vision of Antyodaya, Naidu said providing affordable and nutritious food to the poor, slum dwellers and migrant workers was "a true example of sensitivity and service toward the most vulnerable sections of society." He congratulated the Delhi government for completing the target on Vajpayee's death anniversary.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the milestone reflected the government's commitment to ensuring



AFFORDABLE MEALS

- » Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the milestone reflected the government's commitment to ensuring that no individual sleeps hungry in the nation's Capital
- » Launched by the Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board on December 25, 2025, the scheme offers nutritious meals at Rs 5
- » According to the government, around 95 lakh subsidised meals have already been served, while the 100 canteens now have the capacity to feed nearly one lakh people every day and serve about 3.65 crore meals annually

that "no individual sleeps hungry in the nation's capital." Announcing the expansion of the scheme

to university areas, she said, "Needy students can now access nutritious and affordable food at the Atal

Canteen. The government stands with them and will ensure their hunger is satisfied."

Urban Development Minister Ashish Sood described the initiative as "a resolve to honour the hardworking hands building Delhi," adding that the canteens were not merely about low-cost meals but about protecting the dignity of labourers and economically weaker sections.

Launched by the Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board (DUSIB) on December 25, 2025, the scheme offers nutritious meals at Rs 5. According to the government, around 95 lakh subsidised meals have already been served, while the 100 canteens now have the capacity to feed nearly one lakh people every day and serve about 3.65 crore meals annually. The 25 newly inaugurated canteens have been set up across hospitals, metro stations, resettlement colonies, JJ clusters and market areas, including Delhi University Metro station, AIIMS, LNJP Hospital, Anand Vihar and Narela.

Delhi govt moves towards paperless e-Cabinet system

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 16

The Delhi government has initiated steps to implement a paperless e-Cabinet system, with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday holding a meeting with experts from the National Informatics Centre (NIC) to discuss a secure digital platform for Cabinet functioning.

According to the government, the proposed system will enable Cabinet notes, meeting agendas, annexures, decisions and minutes to be prepared, shared and stored digitally. Ministers and senior officials will be able to access the documents securely on tablets during Cabinet meetings, while role-based access will ensure that only authorised officials can view relevant files.

The government said the e-Cabinet system would allow Cabinet proposals to be submitted, examined, approved and archived online, reducing delays in processing and improving coordination among departments. It will also facilitate monitoring of the implementation of Cabinet decisions to ensure time-bound execution. During the meeting, NIC experts briefed the Chief Minister on the functioning of similar systems already operational in several states, where they have helped improve administrative efficiency and transparency.

Emphasising the need for technology-driven governance, Gupta said, "The Delhi Government aims to develop a system that simplifies government processes, enables faster decision-making and allows continuous monitoring of their implementation."

ARAVALIS IN BLOOM



A common grass yellow butterfly (Eurema hecabe) perches on a purple wildflower in the Aravali mountain ranges, in Gurugram, on Sunday

PTI

DDA flats see rush 37 Sundays, greener Delhi

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

New Delhi, August 16

The DDA Karmajeevi Awaas Yojana 2026 received an overwhelming response on the first day of bookings, with more than 50 per cent of the 1,218 flats on offer 661 flats booked on Sunday. The scheme was launched under the guidance of Lieutenant Governor of Delhi and Chairman, DDA, Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu.

Bookings opened on the occasion of the 80th Independence Day through the First Come, First Serve (FCFS) mode. The 1-BHK category witnessed a particularly strong response, highlighting the preference for affordable housing among homebuyers

and working professionals.

The scheme offers 1,218 ready-to-move flats at Pocket-I1, Sector A1-A4, Narela, at a flat 25 per cent discount. Prices after discount start at Rs 33.40 lakh for 1-BHK, Rs 75.55 lakh for 2-BHK and Rs 1.065 crore for 3-BHK flats. It is designed for serving and retired government employees and working professionals from corporate, business, entrepreneurial and professional sectors. The strong response comes amid robust DDA housing sales in Narela. In the first quarter of the current financial year, DDA sold 1,284 flats, generating over Rs 1,020 crore, with Narela accounting for 1,153 flats, nearly 90 per cent of total sales.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, August 16

The New Delhi Municipal Council's (NDMC) 'EkPed-MaaKeNaam_OnSunday' campaign completed its 37th consecutive Sunday with a plantation drive at the Aditya Sadan NDMC Housing Complex on Ashoka Road on Sunday.

NDMC Vice-Chairperson Kuljeet Singh Chahal led the drive, which saw participation from local residents, RWA representatives, children, women and civic employees. The saplings were planted in honour of mothers, in line with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam' campaign. Chahal said planting a sapling was only the first step and stressed the need for regular watering, protection and maintenance to ensure its growth into a healthy tree. He urged residents to take responsibility for saplings planted in their neighbourhoods. The campaign also served as a platform for residents to raise civic concerns, including monkey menace, maintenance of the park, the need for a lift, improvements to the gym and development of a children's play area. Chahal directed officials to inspect the issues and take time-bound action. Officials from the Civil, Electrical, Health and Horticulture departments attended the programme.

Briefs

Man wanted for wife's murder held

NEW DELHI: A man wanted in connection with the murder of his wife was arrested with an illegal country-made pistol and a live cartridge in his possession, an official said. The accused, Sharvar Ali, was allegedly evading arrest since the murder of his wife Ujma on June 6 in the Bhalswa Dairy area, he said. Proceedings to declare him a proclaimed offender were also underway. Acting on a tip-off, a team conducted an operation in the jurisdiction of the K N Katju Marg area and apprehended Ali for possessing an illegal weapon. "During verification and interrogation, his involvement in the murder case came to light. A separate case was also registered against Ali for possessing an illegal weapon," the officer said.

HC to hear CBI's Kejriwal plea Monday

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court will on Monday hear the CBI's petition challenging a trial court order discharging AAP leaders Arvind Kejriwal, Manish Sisodia and 21 others in the liquor policy case. Justice Manoj Jain is also expected to take up applications by the former Delhi chief minister and his deputy seeking dismissal of the CBI's revision petition for being non-maintainable. Kejriwal and Sisodia, who had earlier boycotted the proceedings in the case before Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma, have claimed that the plea was filed with "unprecedented haste" and in the "most unserious manner", and that they have been unable to even discern the agency's case against them in the "bare-shell" and "non-specific" petition.

DDA maps Yamuna's future

AIMAN FATIMA

New Delhi, August 16

The Delhi Development Authority's (DDA) proposed Master Plan Delhi-2047 (MPD-2047) seeks to strike a delicate balance between improving public access to the Yamuna and safeguarding one of the Capital's most ecologically sensitive landscapes, raising a key policy question. The proposal comes months after the installation of over 300 O-Zone sign boards along the Yamuna triggered concern among residents, highlighting the sensitivity surrounding the protected river corridor.

The Yamuna's O-Zone, spread across nearly 9,934 hectares, has traditionally been treated as an ecologically sensitive floodplain where permanent residential, commercial and urban construction is either prohibited or heavily restricted. Earlier this year, the DDA erected O-Zone boards along the 22-km stretch between Wazirabad and Okhla following court directions, prompting fears among residents that the markings could pave the way for eviction or demolition drives. Chief

Minister Rekha Gupta had assured residents that existing houses would not be demolished and clarified that the court's directions applied only to new constructions, helping ease concerns over large-scale displacement. Against this backdrop, MPD-2047 now proposes a significant policy shift by dividing the existing O-Zone into two planning categories.

The O-1 zone, comprising the riverbed and the defined one-in-25-year floodplain, will continue to remain a strictly protected area where no construction or development will be permitted. The O-2 zone, covering the outer floodplain beyond the core river channel, will allow regulated recreational activities such as parks, green spaces, walking trails and a proposed 52-km cycling track, while prohibiting permanent urban development.

Officials associated with the plan said the objective is not to dilute environmental protection but to make the river more accessible through low-impact public spaces. "The proposal is intended to reconnect people with the Yamuna. The ecologically critical areas will continue to receive the

highest level of protection," an official said.

Environmental experts, however, urged caution. They noted that the National Green Tribunal is yet to complete the scientific demarcation of the Yamuna's floodplain and argued that land-use decisions should follow, not precede, that exercise. "A floodplain performs vital ecological functions, including groundwater recharge and flood moderation. Any increase in public activity must be based on scientific evidence and should not undermine the river's natural resilience. Conservation has to remain the primary objective. We can only hope for a better final decision on this," they said.

The proposal also departs from the draft MPD-2041, which treated the entire floodplain as part of Delhi's green-blue infrastructure and permitted only passive recreation through greenways, cycling and walking trails without altering the single O-Zone classification.

As the Master Plan awaits the Centre's approval, the debate has moved beyond development versus conservation.

Over 5.27 lakh consumers benefit Delhi extends 100% water bill LPSC waiver till March 2027

AIMAN FATIMA

New Delhi, August 16

The Delhi government has extended the 100 per cent waiver of Late Payment Surcharge (LPSC) on outstanding water bills for domestic and non-domestic consumers till March 31, 2027, giving residents and commercial establishments a final opportunity to clear old dues by paying only the principal amount.

According to the Delhi Jal Board (DJB), 5,27,514 consumers have already availed of the scheme, with Rs 3,261 crore in LPSC waived so far. The Board has also recovered Rs 815.84 crore in principal dues under the scheme.

The waiver covers 14.09 lakh domestic and 70,312 commercial consumers across Delhi. Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said the extension balances financial discipline with

HIGHLIGHTS

- » According to the Delhi Jal Board (DJB), 5,27,514 consumers have already availed of the scheme, with Rs 3,261 crore in LPSC waived so far
- » The Board has also recovered Rs 815.84 crore in principal dues under the scheme
- » The waiver covers 14.09 lakh domestic and 70,312 commercial consumers across Delhi

relief for consumers burdened by mounting surcharge liabilities.

He said, "the government wanted people to pay only what they genuinely owed, while the waiver of the entire LPSC would help families and businesses settle long-pending bills." However, he stressed

that "the extension till March 31, 2027, would be the final deadline, and no further extension would be granted." The DJB has instructed its field offices to publicise the settlement scheme and encourage consumers to clear pending principal dues.

The scheme was launched on October 14, 2025, when around 14.6 lakh consumers had pending water bills. At the time, the DJB's total outstanding dues exceeded Rs.87,588 crore, including Rs.7,125 crore in principal and Rs.80,463 crore** as LPSC. In the domestic category alone, pending bills stood at Rs.16,126 crore, comprising Rs.5,057 crore in principal and Rs.11,069 crore in LPSC.

Originally scheduled to end on March 31, 2026, the scheme was first extended to August 15, 2026, before the latest extension.

AIMAN FATIMA

New Delhi, August 16

The MPD-2027 accessed by *Millennium Post* reveals rebuilding of Delhi from within, acknowledging that it has little scope for horizontal expansion, the plan makes urban regeneration the cornerstone of the capital's future growth. Approved by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) on August 12, the plan seeks to redevelop ageing planned colonies, upgrade unauthorised settlements and rehabilitate slums to accommodate a projected population of 3.2 crore by 2047.

Redeveloping ageing Delhi

The plan proposes regeneration across planned residential neighbourhoods, including DDA housing, Cooperative Group Housing Societies (CGHS), Cooperative House Building Societies (CHBS), government housing, resettlement and

rehabilitation colonies. Redevelopment will also cover commercial centres, industrial estates and public institutions.

"For planned residential areas, regeneration can be undertaken on a minimum 3,000 sq m plot, while commercial, industrial and public/semi-public areas require 1,000 sq m. Projects will be allowed up to 1.5 times the base FAR, with amalgamation and reconstitution of plots permitted. Every scheme must prepare a Road Network Plan, while agencies will be responsible for upgrading water supply, sewerage, roads and other civic infrastructure."

The plan also mandates sustainable features such as dual plumbing, decentralised sewage treatment, water reuse, solid waste management, renewable energy and Net Zero practices.

Framework for unauthorised colonies

MPD-2047 provides a dedicated regeneration model for unauthorised colonies through schemes covering a minimum 2,000 sq m. These can be undertaken by developers, RWAs or authorised resident groups.

The schemes will allow a base FAR of 350, with an additional Amenities FAR of 20-50 for creating public facilities. Up to 15 per cent of the permissible FAR can be used for neighbourhood facilities, including 5 per cent for local commercial use. Larger projects must reserve 10 per cent land as public open space and earmark land for schools, health centres, community halls, childcare centres, police posts and other civic facilities. Adjoining colonies may also be redeveloped together for integrated planning.

Three-pronged strategy for slums

Instead of relying solely on rehabilitation, the plan proposes a three-fold

approach for slums and JJ clusters, in-situ rehabilitation, relocation and in-situ upgradation.

Eligible in-situ rehabilitation projects will be permitted FAR of 500 each for rehabilitation and remunerative components, with no height restriction subject to statutory approvals. At least 40% of the project area must be reserved for rehabilitation housing under the "Jahan Jhuggi, Wahan Makan" principle. However, JJ clusters located on the Yamuna floodplain, ridge, forests, biodiversity parks, railway safety zones and other environmentally sensitive areas will be relocated instead of being redeveloped in situ.

The regeneration-first approach marks a significant shift in Delhi's planning philosophy, with the city seeking to create new housing and infrastructure primarily by rebuilding existing neighbourhoods rather than expanding its urban footprint.

CHAMOLI TUNNE ACCIDENT

Search for two missing workers continues; magisterial inquiry ordered

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Gopeshwar, August 16

Search operations to locate two workers who went missing after a tunnel accident in Uttarakhand’s Chamoli district continued on Sunday, the fourth day since the incident, while a magisterial inquiry was ordered to ascertain its causes and circumstances, officials said.

Teams from the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), State Disaster Response Force (SDRF), Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP), police and other agencies have been conducting an intensive search for the workers since the accident on August 13, they said.

The under-construction THDC India Limited tunnel at Pipalkoti was inundated with debris and water following a landslide on Thursday evening. Eight people were killed in the accident, while two workers remain missing. Twelve other workers who were injured were rescued from the tunnel and hospitalised.

The missing workers have been identified as Lucas Topno from Jharkhand and Chetan Poyam from Chhattisgarh, officials said.

The tunnel remains flooded and water is being



National Disaster Response Force personnel wade through deep water and sludge during a search and rescue operation inside an under-construction hydroelectric project tunnel, in Chamoli, Sunday

KEY POINTS

- » The under-construction THDC India Limited tunnel at Pipalkoti was inundated with debris and water following a landslide on Thursday evening
- » Twelve other workers who were injured were rescued from the tunnel and hospitalised

continuously pumped out to lower the water level and enable rescue teams to access the affected

areas, they said. Work is also underway to remove machinery and other heavy obstructions trapped inside

the tunnel.

Modern equipment and technical resources are being used to clear debris and obstructions, while rescue teams are checking every possible area, including small gaps within the debris, officials said.

Chamoli District Magistrate Gaurav Kumar said a magisterial inquiry has been ordered to investigate the causes and circumstances of the accident.

Necessary action will be taken in accordance with the rules based on the findings of the inquiry, he said.

State Disaster Management and Rehabilitation Minister Madan Kaushik reviewed the ongoing relief and rescue operations in Gopeshwar on Sunday.

The meeting began with a tribute to the workers who lost their lives in the accident and a two-minute silence.

Torrential rain disrupts normal life in Himachal Pradesh

109 roads blocked, orange alert in four districts

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Shimla, August 16

Torrential rain led to the closure of 109 roads across Himachal Pradesh on Sunday, with the local meteorological office issuing an orange alert for heavy to very heavy rain at isolated places in four districts on August 17 and 18.

The orange alert has been issued across Bilaspur, Chamba, Kangra and Mandi districts for Monday, and in Una, Chamba and Kangra districts for Tuesday, the Met office said.

Two families at Thakurdwara near Palampur in Kangra district had a narrow escape on Sunday morning after a tree fell on their building, officials said.

The building, adjacent shops and parked vehicles were damaged in the tree collapse, leading to a brief traffic congestion on the Palampur-Hamirpur highway, they said.



People cover themselves as they walk amid rainfall, at Ridge in Shimla, Himachal Pradesh

Moderate to heavy rain lashed parts of Kangra district since Saturday evening. Dharamshala recorded 126.3 mm of rainfall in the past 24 hours, followed by Palampur at 55 mm and Kangra at 34.6 mm, Met office data showed.

According to the State Emergency Operations Centre, 43 roads were closed in Mandi, 33 in Kullu, eight in Sirmaur, seven in Shimla, six each in Chamba and Kangra, four in Una and two in Lahaul-Spiti.

As many as 216 water

supply lines and seven power transformers were also damaged in the rain, the officials said.

Since the onset of monsoon on June 30, 79 people have died in rain-related incidents in the state, including 14 in landslides and one in a flash flood.

The state has suffered estimated losses of Rs 973 crore so far, the officials said. Himachal Pradesh has received 128.3 mm of rainfall against a normal of 156.5 mm from August 1-16, a deficit of 18 per cent, they said.

Demonstration, torch rally held to press demand for NRC before census in Manipur

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Imphal, August 16

Students, demanding implementation of the NRC in Manipur before going ahead with the census, staged a demonstration outside the Directorate of Census Operations here on Sunday, prompting the

police to fire tear gas shells to disperse them, officials said.

Hundreds of protesters in Imphal East and Imphal West districts also held a torch rally in the evening, demanding implementation of the National Register of Citizens (NRC) before any census activity in the state to identify illegal immigrants.

From page 1

Indonesia

Muslim-majority Indonesia. They focused on three regencies that remained inaccessible after the earthquake: the hardest-hit Manggarai, East Manggarai and Nagekeo.

“We have cleared most landslides and reopened roads to previously isolated villages, although communication disruptions and power outages continue to hamper search efforts,” said Fathur Rahman, head of the Search and Rescue Office in Maumere, the capital of Sikka regency.

The National Search and Rescue Agency said 101 people were injured. More than 900 homes were destroyed and 450 more damaged, forcing about 5,000 people into temporary shelters. Thousands at Labuan Bajo, the gateway to Komodo National Park, one of Indonesia’s best-known tourist destinations, spent the night outdoors, fearing strong aftershocks.

“The shaking was terrifying, so intense that my house nearly collapsed,” said Anastasia Imad, a farmer, speaking from a makeshift green tent beside her damaged home. “We feared the aftershocks would bring it down on us while we slept.”

Landslides blocked sections of the Trans-Flores Highway, a roughly 700-kilometre (435-mile) road linking communities across the mountainous island.

Meanwhile, relief workers distributed rice, ready-to-eat meals, drinking water, blankets and medicine, while emergency shelters were being set up for displaced residents. Authorities said restoring electricity and communications, as well as delivering aid to remote villages isolated by landslides, remained among the biggest challenges.

Indonesia, an archipelago of more than 17,000 islands, is prone to earthquakes and volcanic eruptions because of its location on the Pacific “Ring of Fire”, a horseshoe-shaped arc of seismic faults and volcanoes.

Flores has experienced some of the country’s deadliest disasters. A powerful earthquake and tsunami in 1992 killed about 2,500 people on the island.

In 2018, a magnitude 7.5 earthquake triggered a tsunami on Sulawesi that killed more than 4,400 people. In 2004, a

magnitude 9.1 quake off Sumatra unleashed a tsunami that killed about 230,000 people in a dozen countries.

Asish Banerjee

throughout his political career and shared a good relationship with him. Adhikari also spoke to the family over a video call and assured them he would visit them.

Former Chief Minister and TMC chairperson Mamata Banerjee said Ashish Banerjee had been “repeatedly maligned, falsely accused and subjected to relentless pressure”. The party accused the BJP and a section of the media of maligning him.

In the purported one-page note, Banerjee allegedly wrote: “I never got involved in corruption; entering politics was the mistake,” and claimed he had been falsely accused. Referring to the Tarapith Rampurhat Development Authority (TRDA), he allegedly said no files were given to him for 3.5 years, he was not on the Tender Committee and had no cheque-signing power.

Banerjee’s wife said he had never been involved in wrongdoing but was repeatedly branded a “thief”. She alleged that the humiliation, allegations and mental pressure contributed to his death.

The political row intensified after an old video surfaced, purportedly showing BJP’s Burdwan North Assembly No. 6 mandal president Soumitra Ghosh confronting Banerjee while he was travelling to Kolkata for the July 21 rally. Ghosh is allegedly heard threatening to beat him up, saying he had refrained because of Banerjee’s age. TMC leader Kunal Ghosh sought an impartial probe.

Adhikari said the investigation would also examine whether Banerjee was threatened or blackmailed, including by members of his own party.

TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee condemned the alleged branding of people as “thieves” and called for scrutiny of the circumstances surrounding the death. TMC MP Samirul Islam visited the family.

BJP’s Dhruva Saha, who defeated Banerjee in the 2026 Assembly election, said he had met him a few days earlier and noticed nothing unusual. “There must be some reason behind this. Police should investigate all

possibilities,” he said.

Earlier this year, Banerjee resigned as chairman of the TMC’s Birbhum district core committee and subsequently joined the Ritabrata-led TMC faction. Rebel faction leader Akhruzzaman said a delegation would visit Rampurhat and seek an impartial investigation.

NTA

about the three papers led to a committee review.

The panel found factual, typographical and translation errors, including misspelt names of scholars, garbled book titles, problems in question wording, grammatical, gender and number agreement errors, punctuation mistakes and non-standard coined terms for established concepts. A significant number of questions had been repeated from earlier examinations.

The committee recommended re-conducting the papers to ensure fairness. The NTA said defects of this extent could not be addressed simply by dropping questions after the challenge process.

Results for 84 subjects, for which the Answer Key Challenge was issued on Sunday, will be declared as scheduled. JRF seat allocation and e-certificates for those subjects will not be delayed.

The number of candidates qualifying for Assistant Professor eligibility will be 6 per cent of those appearing in June 2026 or the retest, whichever is higher. For these subjects, allocations for JRF, Assistant Professor eligibility and PhD admission will follow the Information Bulletin. Allocations already made will not be reduced after the retest.

Details of exam cities, centres and admit cards will be notified on the website.

NLSIU

professional consequences for dissent.

They objected to Mishra and CJI Kant attending the NLSIU convocation, saying inviting officials who had expressed disapproval of students would undermine the event.

On August 14, Kant said, “It’s a dialogue between students and me,” while pulling up the BCI over its order. A CJI-led bench said students had a right to protest. The BCI withdrew the order within hours following an uproar on social media.

Rahman’s India visit

Dhaka said a “propitious environment” needed to be created before the visit could proceed.

Bangladesh Foreign Ministry spokesperson AKM Shahidul Karim said officials from the two countries had been discussing a possible bilateral visit by Rahman for several weeks. However, he said the process was affected by a virtual press interaction held by Hasina in New Delhi on August 5.

“We have requested the Indian authorities to expeditiously act on our request to extradite Sheikh Hasina and other fugitive criminals,” Karim said. He also sought the handover of those accused in the killing of student leader Sharif Osman Hadi under the bilateral extradition treaty.

Hadi, who was involved in the student-led movement that removed Hasina in 2024, was killed in December 2025. Three suspects in the case were arrested in India in March and are in judicial custody in West Bengal.

India has agreed to extradite them to Bangladesh after completion of due process.

Rahman had raised both extradition matters during his August 10 meeting with Indian High Commissioner Dinesh Trivedi. Bangladesh has repeatedly sought Hasina’s return since she fled to India after being removed from power in August 2024.

She was sentenced to death in absentia by a Bangladeshi tribunal in November 2025 for crimes against humanity.

India has said the extradition request for Hasina remains under examination under applicable law and established legal procedures.

New Delhi also clarified on August 7 that it had no role in the August 5 media interaction involving Hasina.

Meanwhile, India’s Ministry of External Affairs said on August 14 that Rahman had been invited both for a bilateral visit and to attend the BRICS outreach session. Bangladesh currently holds the chairmanship of BIMSTEC.

Karim said Dhaka would continue its “Bangladesh First” policy based on sovereign equality, national dignity, non-interfer-

ence and mutual benefit.

Shah targets

imprisonment for singing the song during the freedom struggle.

The controversy followed visuals from the Congress event showing senior leaders speaking among themselves while Vande Mataram was being recited. BJP leader Amit Malviya alleged that Sonia Gandhi objected to the full rendition after the opening stanzas and that Rahul Gandhi appeared to signal for it to end.

The Congress rejected the allegations, saying Sonia Gandhi’s actions were aimed at ensuring proper arrangements for the rendition and had nothing to do with stopping the song.

Shah also accused the Congress of having “forgotten Vande Mataram due to vote-bank politics”. He said the song was sung at the Red Fort and other flag-hoisting events on the 80th anniversary of Independence.

Vimal Elaichi ad

receipt to submit written explanations and supporting documents. They may also seek a personal hearing, either themselves or through an authorised representative.

According to the FDA, the use of the name “VIMAL Elaichi” in the campaign may create an association with the Vimal Pan Masala brand and could mislead consumers by indirectly promoting a prohibited product.

The department said the issue was of particular concern because the advertisement uses the same brand identity associated with Vimal Pan Masala.

The FDA described the notice as a “final warning” and said the advertisement appeared to be a misleading food advertisement, potentially violating provisions of the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006, and regulations framed under it.

It also pointed to possible violations relating to surrogate or indirect advertising under other applicable laws and guidelines.

The actors have been directed to immediately stop participating in or endorsing the Vimal Pan Masala/Elaichi advertisement and remove the promotional material from their official social media accounts, websites and other digital platforms under their control.

They have also been told not

to assist in its broadcast, publication, dissemination or promotion in any form.

The FDA has sought documentary evidence establishing whether Vimal Elaichi is an independently marketed product available for sale or whether it is being used as a brand extension to promote Vimal pan masala or tobacco-related products. The actors must also provide copies of their endorsement agreements, campaign briefs, product information, payment arrangements and details of the advertising agency and brand owner involved.

Details of all television channels, digital platforms, social media accounts and other media where the advertisement appeared, along with the period of its dissemination, have also been sought.

The notice asks for disclosure of any material connection between the actors and the advertiser or brand owner.

The action follows the Maharashtra Food Safety Commissioner’s July 13 prohibition order issued under Section 30(2)(a) of the Food Safety and Standards Act.

The order is valid for one year and covers specified tobacco, nicotine and areca-nut-based prohibited food products.

The FDA said Vimal is prominently associated with pan masala in Maharashtra, where enforcement action is being taken against the manufacture, storage, transport, distribution and sale of prohibited pan masala products.

Copies of the notice have been sent to the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) and the Central Consumer Protection Authority for information and appropriate action.

The FDA has also referred to the Food Safety and Standards (Advertising and Claims) Regulations, 2018, which require advertising claims to be truthful, clear and not misleading.

Regulation 15 provides for discontinuation and corrective advertisements.

Under Section 21 of the Consumer Protection Act, the Central Consumer Protection Authority can order the discontinuation or modification of misleading advertisements and impose penalties on endorsers. In specified cases, it can also bar an endorser from promoting products or services for a

prescribed period.

The notice warns that if the actors fail to respond within the stipulated 15 days, or if their explanations are found unsatisfactory, further action may be taken without another notice. The FDA, under Commissioner Tukaram Mundhe, has also been conducting inspections of food outlets and products across Maharashtra as part of its food safety and hygiene enforcement measures.

States brace

and Sikkim. North Odisha and Gangetic West Bengal may receive isolated extremely heavy rain on Monday, while very heavy rainfall is likely in parts of Odisha and Jharkhand.

The western Himalayan region is also expected to remain wet, with fairly widespread rain across Himachal Pradesh, Jammu and Kashmir, Ladakh and Uttarakhand through the week.

Isolated very heavy rain is possible in Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand. Delhi, Haryana, Chandigarh and Punjab are likely to see another spell of widespread rain around August 18, while East Uttar Pradesh could receive heavy rainfall.

The Northeast is also expected to experience heavy rain in Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Meghalaya, Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram and Tripura. Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh are likely to receive fairly widespread rain, while Gujarat, Maharashtra, Konkan and Goa may also see widespread showers. Karnataka, Kerala and Mahe are forecast to receive widespread rainfall, with isolated heavy rain possible in Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Karaikal.

The continuing weather has added to a growing relief and infrastructure challenge.

Himachal Pradesh has reported more than Rs 886 crore in property damage, while Jammu and Kashmir has sought special central assistance for restoration work. Flooded farmland in Assam and disrupted Himalayan highways have added to the impact.

In Delhi, the IMD has forecast generally cloudy skies and light rain till August 21.

Temperatures are expected to remain between 32 and 35 degrees Celsius during the day and 22 to 25 degrees Celsius at night.



SIMPLE ACCESSIBLE EMPOWERED



Shri Vishnu Deo Sai
Hon'ble Chief Minister of Chhattisgarh

REFORMS AND INNOVATIONS

Transforming the Vision of Progress and
Prosperity into Reality



Shri Narendra Modi
Hon'ble Prime Minister of India

Administrative Reforms



- ▶ Department of Good Governance and Convergence established
- ▶ Promotion of e-Governance and e-Office systems
- ▶ Atal Dashboard
- ▶ Chief Minister's Good Governance Fellowship
- ▶ CM Helpline 1076

Revenue & Registration Reforms



- ▶ Transformation of **119** Registration Offices into smart offices
- ▶ Geo-referencing to prevent land disputes
- ▶ Simplified registry process through **10** revolutionary reforms and the Sugam App
- ▶ Ownership rights granted under forest rights titles (patta)

Ease of Doing Business



- ▶ First state to implement **Jan Vishwas 2.0**
- ▶ Faster approvals through the **Invest Chhattisgarh Portal** with one-click single-window clearance
- ▶ **Startup and Innovation** Policy 2025–30 implemented
- ▶ Recognised as a "High Performer" among landlocked states/regions in **LEADS 2025** by the Government of India

Digitalisation of Public Services



- ▶ Atal Panchayat Digital Suvidha Kendras in **6000+** Gram Panchayats
- ▶ More than **790** citizen services available on the Sewa Setu portal
- ▶ Hassle-free online process for temporary electricity connection

Transparency & Anti-Corruption Measures



- ▶ Government procurement through the GeM Portal
- ▶ Transparent recruitment examinations backed by stringent anti-cheating laws.
- ▶ Transparent mineral transit pass system
- ▶ Transparent e-auction of timber and mineral blocks

EDITORIAL

Fluke or Arrival?

Bangladesh's nine-wicket demolition of Australia in Darwin is not merely an upset to be filed among cricket's delightful accidents. It is a result that demands a rewriting of assumptions about Bangladesh as a Test nation. For a side routinely patronised as dangerous mainly on slow pitches at home, winning Down Under – comprehensively, ruthlessly and without requiring fortune to intervene – represents an extraordinary coming of age. Australia were bundled out for 198 after choosing to bat, before Bangladesh piled up 426 and seized a formidable 228-run lead. Even Cameron Green's defiant century could only postpone the inevitable as Australia managed 284 in their second innings. Bangladesh then swept aside the 57-run target for the loss of one wicket, sealing their first Test victory on Australian soil and only their second against Australia.

More significant than the margin was the manner of victory. Hasan Mahmud ripped through Australia with six wickets in the first innings and nine in the match, while Mehidy Hasan Miraz demonstrated precisely why he has become indispensable to Bangladesh, contributing 65 with the bat before taking five wickets in Australia's second innings. Tanzid Hasan's century gave Bangladesh what touring sides desperately require in Australia: authority at the top rather than excuses about alien conditions. Bangladesh did not stumble upon an Australian collapse and cling desperately to an advantage. They created the collapse, built an enormous lead and then strangled Australia's attempt at recovery. This was not Bangladesh surviving Australia. It was Bangladesh bullying Australia – on Australian soil.

That distinction matters enormously. Australia have spent generations turning home Test cricket into an examination of technique, temperament and nerve that visiting teams frequently fail. In Darwin, the intimidation was reversed. Bangladesh's fast bowlers attacked rather than merely contained, their batters occupied the crease with purpose and their spinners refused to become peripheral figures in conditions supposedly unsuited to them. For Bangladesh, whose Test journey since 2000 has contained too many crushing defeats, false dawns and questions about whether its domestic structure can produce players equipped for the longest format, this victory carries significance far beyond the scorecard. Overseas Test victories have been precious precisely because consistency away from home has remained one of the great unresolved weaknesses of Bangladesh cricket.

Yet one magnificent Test cannot be allowed to become another isolated monument. Bangladesh have produced historic victories before, only to retreat into inconsistency. Darwin must instead become a reference point for what this team should now demand of itself. The second Test offers the possibility of something even greater: a series triumph in Australia. For the hosts, this defeat should be deeply embarrassing; they were beaten in virtually every department in their own backyard. For Bangladesh, however, the greater consequence should be psychological. Respect in Test cricket is not permanently bestowed by administrators or rankings; it is seized through victories in hostile territory. Bangladesh have just seized a considerable amount of it. The challenge is to ensure Darwin is remembered not as a miracle, but as the day Bangladesh stopped being surprised by its own ability to win.

LETTER



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Accountability

Notices to Shah Rukh Khan, Ajay Devgn and Tiger Shroff over Vimal Elaichi advertisements highlight a serious concern. Celebrities must recognise that surrogate promotions can normalise tobacco-linked brands, particularly among impressionable young audiences.

HANSHIKA SINGH,
LUDHIANA

You can also send your comments to The Editor, Millennium Post, Pratap Bhawan, 5 Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg, New Delhi 110 002

Securing a New Dawn

The CRPF's journey reflects how welfare, modernisation, leadership and sustained operations reshaped India's fight against Left-Wing Extremism

CRPF AT 88



SANJAY KUMAR JHA

THE WRITER IS A FORMER DGP OF MADHYA PRADESH

Nations are built twice: first through political freedom and then through institutions capable of protecting that freedom. Few institutions embody that responsibility more than the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF). Since its inception, the CRPF has stood at the forefront of India's internal security architecture, responding to the nation's most complex challenges, from maintaining public order to combating insurgencies and terrorism across diverse and difficult terrains.

As the CRPF commemorated its 88th Raising Day on July 27, it celebrated nearly nine decades of courage and sacrifice, while reflecting on a significant transformation in India's internal security strategy. This transformation rested on four pillars: personnel welfare, operational modernisation, direct political engagement, and targeted security operations alongside sustained development.

For decades, CRPF personnel operated under some of the country's most demanding conditions. Dense forests, unfamiliar

terrain and unpredictable guerrilla warfare required extraordinary courage, often at enormous personal cost. PM Modi's government placed personnel welfare and modernisation at the heart of India's security architecture.

A series of welfare initiatives, including Ayushman CAPF, the CAPF e-Awas Portal, CAPF Punarvaas and the Welfare and Rehabilitation Board, strengthened healthcare, housing, rehabilitation and financial security for personnel and their families. The introduction of honorary ranks for eligible CAPF and Assam Rifles personnel and operational casualty certificates, on the lines of the armed forces, ensured that service and sacrifice received greater institutional recognition.

The government simultaneously accelerated the modernisation of the force through Modernisation Plan IV. Advanced weapons, surveillance technologies, secure communications, specialised vehicles and protective equipment transformed CRPF operations. Better intelligence, superior equipment and technological precision reduced operational risks, improved mission effectiveness and, most importantly, minimised casualties among security personnel. Capability, however, delivers results when matched by leadership.

Under the strategic guidance of Union Home and Cooperation Minister Amit Shah, the government has transformed the CRPF into the driving force behind India's campaign to replace the Red Corridor with a development corridor.

Throughout the campaign, Amit Shah consistently chose engagement over distance. He travelled repeatedly to CRPF camps in challenging operational theatres, including Bastar and the forward tactical camp at Basaguda in Chhattisgarh. Often visiting soon after major anti-Naxal operations, he interacted



Security created space, but governance consolidated gains

MODERNISATION, PERSONNEL WELFARE AND INTELLIGENCE-LED OPERATIONS HAVE PLACED THE CRPF AT THE CENTRE OF INDIA'S CHANGING INTERNAL SECURITY LANDSCAPE

directly with jawans, reviewed operational preparedness and met injured personnel.

These visits reinforced confidence among personnel, strengthened coordination between policymakers and field commanders, and ensured that operational decisions reflected ground realities. The physical presence of the Union Home Minister in active conflict zones sent a clear message that the nation's political leadership stood firmly behind those serving on the frontlines.

Under Amit Shah's guidance, the force emerged as the operational backbone of

India's campaign against Left-Wing Extremism. The CRPF spearheaded intelligence-led operations that systematically dismantled Maoist infrastructure across central India. Its specialised CoBRA battalions led landmark missions, including Operation Black Forest, Operation Octopus, Operation Double Bull and Operations Chakrabandha, significantly weakening the operational capability of the CPI (Maoist).

Operation Black Forest alone eliminated 27 hardcore Maoists, while sustained operations compelled the People's Liberation Army to abandon several long-held strongholds. Security forces restored the writ of the state across strategic locations, including Budha Pahad, Parasnath, Barasmiya, Chakrabandha, Karreguttalu and Abujhmad, areas that had remained Maoist bastions for decades.

Amit Shah set a national objective of making India free from Left-Wing Extremism by March 31, 2026. Intelligence-led operations neutralised several senior Maoist leaders, including Basarvaju, Patiram Manjhi, Ganesh Uike and Milind Teltumbde. Sustained pressure triggered large-scale surrenders

across Chhattisgarh, Telangana and Maharashtra. Naxal violence declined by 56%, security force fatalities fell by 75%, civilian deaths declined by 70%, and the number of affected districts reduced from 126 in 2014 to a single district of concern by 2026, with none remaining in the "most affected" category.

Since 2014, the Modi government established 594 fortified police stations and 408 security camps, and built over 12,200 kilometres of roads in previously inaccessible regions. Coordinated action by state governments, the Enforcement Directorate and the National Investigation Agency disrupted the financial architecture of Maoist organisations, leading to the seizure of assets worth over Rs 102 crore. Expanded telecommunications, banking infrastructure, post offices, industrial training institutes, skill development centres and rehabilitation policies restored governance, created economic opportunities and encouraged former Maoist cadres to return to the mainstream.

Regions once synonymous with violence became connected by roads, institutions, markets and public services. Security created the space, governance consolidated the gains and development ensured they endured. The Red Corridor gradually evolved into a development corridor.

This journey from the Red Corridor to a development corridor represents the evolution of India's internal security philosophy, and the CRPF has become a critical partner in nation-building, creating a secure environment where governance can flourish, investment can reach previously isolated communities, and development can replace decades of conflict. That is the defining legacy of the CRPF at 88.

Views expressed are personal

Making Justice Accessible

A SC bench in Kolkata could make justice more affordable across eastern and northeastern India

EQUAL REACH



JYOTIPROKASH
CHATTERJEE

THE WRITER IS THE NATIONAL PRESIDENT, NCPI

must be accessible to everyone. But accessibility is not merely the legal right to approach a court; it is also about whether a person can realistically reach it and pursue a case. This is where Kolkata can play an important role. A major centre of eastern India, the city has a long administrative, commercial, cultural and legal history. The Calcutta High Court is among the country's oldest, while Kolkata has deep links with eastern and northeastern India.

If India considers a regional Supreme Court bench for the eastern region, Kolkata would be a natural choice. There is also constitutional scope for it. Article 130 provides that while the Supreme Court sits in Delhi, the Chief Justice of India, with the President's approval, may designate other places for it to sit. The Constitution itself allows for the Supreme Court to sit outside Delhi, subject to the proper constitutional and institutional process. The idea, therefore, is not without constitutional basis and also has a history behind it.

In its 229th Report in 2009, the Law Commission recommended decentralising the Supreme Court's judicial work. It proposed retaining a Constitution Bench in Delhi and setting up four regional Cassation Benches, with Kolkata serving the eastern region, covering West Bengal, Bihar, Odisha, Jharkhand, Assam, Sikkim, the other northeastern states and the Andaman and Nicobar Islands. The idea, therefore, has been formally considered before.

The proposal was not implemented after the Supreme Court's Full Court rejected it in 2010. But much has changed since then. India's population and casel-



A regional bench could reduce the burden on litigants

ACCESS TO JUSTICE SHOULD NOT BECOME A PRIVILEGE LIMITED TO THOSE WHO CAN AFFORD TO TRAVEL ACROSS THE COUNTRY

oad have grown, connectivity has improved, and digital hearings and video conferencing have transformed court functioning. In this changed environment, the proposal deserves another look. A regional bench would primarily benefit litigants and the legal system, but its impact could extend beyond the courtroom, bringing lawyers, litigants, court

officials, journalists, researchers and others to Kolkata.

This would create greater demand for hotels, restaurants, taxis, car rentals, office spaces, legal services, books and other businesses, generating direct and indirect employment and strengthening Kolkata as a legal and professional services centre. Tourism could also benefit. Visitors staying for court cases may explore the Victoria Memorial, Indian Museum, Jorasanko, Kumartuli, Dakshineswar or Belur Math.

A Supreme Court bench alone will not transform Kolkata's economy or tourism, but such an important national institution could certainly generate additional economic activity.

One point must be made clearly: the demand for a regional bench in Kolkata should not be seen as "Kolkata versus Delhi." Delhi would remain the

principal seat of the Supreme Court. The question is whether the country's highest court can also become more accessible to people living thousands of kilometres away.

The objective should be simple: a person's ability to pursue justice should not depend so heavily on where he or she lives or how much money is available for travel to Delhi. For people in eastern and northeastern India, a regional bench in Kolkata could significantly reduce the burden of distance and expense. At the same time, Kolkata could benefit as a centre for law, professional services, employment and related economic activity.

Most importantly, the issue deserves serious discussion within the constitutional framework. Article 130 already allows the Supreme Court to sit at places other than Delhi, subject to the prescribed process. The question is whether the time has come to revisit the idea. This should not be driven by regional sentiment or political rivalry, but by a simple question: How can we make justice more accessible to ordinary citizens?

If justice is a fundamental right, access to it should not become a privilege limited to those who can afford to travel across the country. A regional bench of the Supreme Court in Kolkata could bring the highest court closer to millions across eastern and northeastern India. This is not merely a demand for Bengal, but for easier, more affordable and accessible justice.

A Regional Bench of the Supreme Court in Kolkata is not just a demand. It is, perhaps, the need of the hour.

Views expressed are personal

12 YEARS FROM THE RED FORT

From Access to Aspiration

Across 12 Independence Day addresses, PM Narendra Modi's changing vocabulary traces India's journey from fixing basic deficits to pursuing technological, economic and strategic ambition

There is a simple way to measure the distance India has travelled in the last decade: listen to the Prime Minister's Independence Day speeches.

In the early years of the Modi Government, the speeches were often about problems that we may today consider as ordinary: toilets, electricity, poverty, roads, bank accounts, fertiliser shortages. But the Prime Minister's tone was urgent when he addressed them. The challenge was to fix what was broken, reach those who had been left out.

Over the years, his vocabulary began to change. The conversation moved from access to aspiration, from plugging gaps to building capabilities, from solving immediate problems to creating systems that could prevent those problems from defining India again.

Perhaps that is also why the length and sweep of his Independence Day addresses have become a phenomenon in themselves.

For a Prime Minister whose working life is famously relentless, the sheer time devoted to presenting the nation's journey from the Red Fort is telling. These are not simply annual speeches; read together, they become something closer to a running record of the country's transformation.

Toilets → Semiconductors

2014 - Can't we just make arrangements for toilets for the dignity of our mothers and sisters?

2026 - In today's digital world and technology-driven era, we understand the importance of the chip. Whether it is electronic goods, medical equipment, or transportation systems, chips are indispensable everywhere. The world has reached a point where the entire system could come to a standstill without chips. That is why Bharat has begun establishing its own semiconductor manufacturing capacity in the direction of becoming self-reliant.

Rural Roads → Satellites → Manned Space Missions → AI and Quantum computing

2016 - Rural roads are a perpetual issue in our country. Each rural citizen craves concrete roads.

2018 - Our scientists launched more than 100 satellites in one go, leaving the world astonished.

2024 - I have noticed that there has been a new atmosphere of interest in science and technology in our schools and colleges after the success of the Chandrayaan mission.

2025 - We are preparing for Aatmanirbhar Bharat Gaganyaan on our own in space. We are working towards building our own space station.

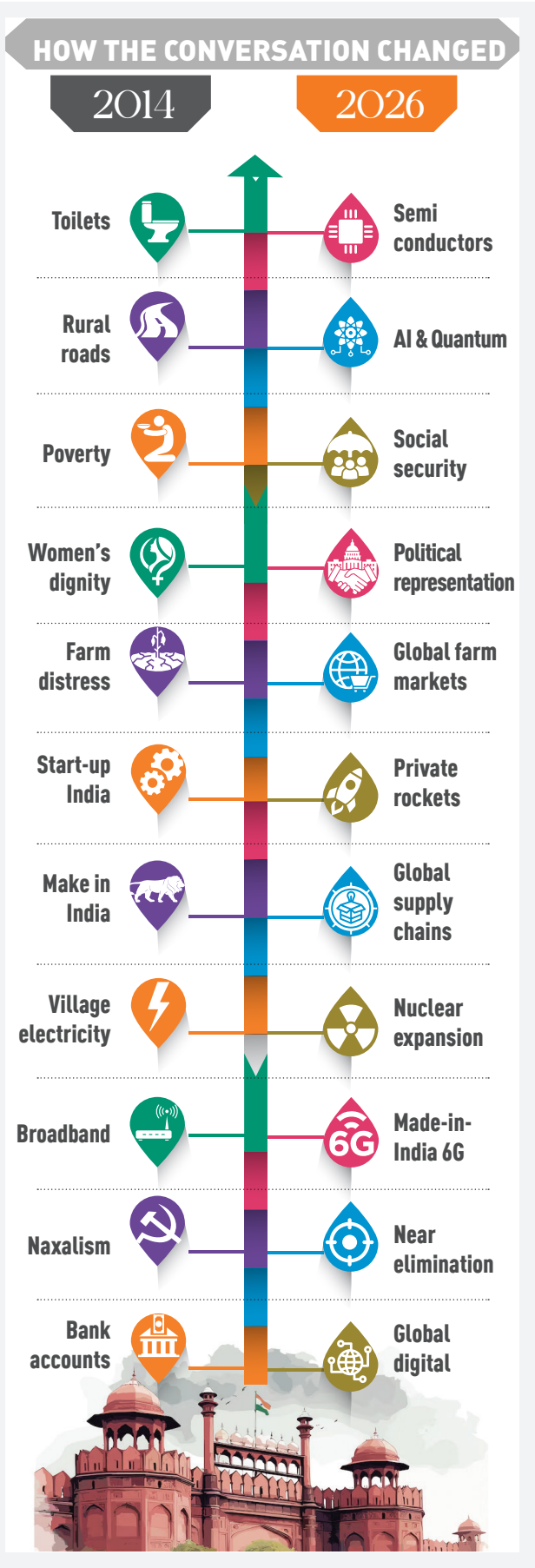
2026 - Today is the age of AI, quantum technology, space, robotics and data centres. An entirely new domain has opened up. Emerging technologies are challenging us every moment. Therefore, we must not merely turn our country into a market for the world; we must become a hub of innovation

Fighting Against Poverty

2014 - If the people of India could remove such a big empire without the power of the government, without weapons and even without resources, then friends, it is the need of the hour to eradicate poverty. Can we not overcome poverty? Can we not defeat poverty? My 125 crore dear countrymen, let us resolve to eradicate poverty, to win against it.

2026 - The resolve for a developed India will be fulfilled only when development reaches the last person. Before 2014, only 25 crore people had social security cover..We have provided social security cover to 100 crore countrymen within a decade.

THE CONVERSATION MOVED FROM ACCESS TO ASPIRATION, FROM PLUGGING GAPS TO BUILDING CAPABILITIES



also. From design to manufacturing, India must emerge as a trusted hub in the global supply chain.

Village Electrification → Nuclear Energy Expansion

2015 - The target of providing electric poles, electric wires and electricity to these 18,500 villages would be achieved within the next 1000 days.

2026 - Energy security is the need of the hour, and therefore, we have already taken a series of strong steps in this direction. One major means of ensuring energy security is nuclear energy. By passing the SHANTI Act in Parliament, we have paved the way towards a new goal. By 2047, we are working towards a target of 100 gigawatts of nuclear power. Within this very decade, we have set a target of starting five new nuclear reactors.

Internet Connectivity

2015 - You can imagine what a quality education the children in villages will get if all the villages of India are connected with Broadband Connectivity and if we can give long-distance education to the schools in every remote corner of the villages.

2024 - We have also seen the days when we had to struggle even for 2G. We are already working in mission mode for 6G, and we shall surprise the world with our progress.

2026 - The number of internet users and consumers has increased nearly fourfold. The number of patents granted has increased fourfold. Digital transactions have increased 100 times.

Our goal should be to ensure that Made-in-India 6G reaches every corner of the world. We must accelerate our efforts in this direction, and our commitment to this endeavour must not diminish.

Naxalism/LWE

2017 - I deeply appreciate the efforts of security forces in curbing Left Wing extremism, which mobilised a lot of youth from these regions to surrender and join the mainstream.

2018 - Left Wing Extremism, Maoism have been bleeding the country. Violent incidents, people fleeing from homes and hiding in forests were a matter of daily occurrence.

Because of continuous efforts by our security forces, the launch of development projects and efforts to connect the people with the national mainstream, left-wing extremism, which affected 126 districts, has now been reduced to 90 districts.

2025 - There was a time when Naxalism had taken root in more than 125 districts. Our tribal areas and youth were caught in the clutches of Maoism. Today, we have reduced that number from over 125 districts to merely 20.

2026 - When you gave us the opportunity to serve in 2014, we made a resolve on that very day to free the country from Naxalism. Today, I am happy to say that Naxalite-Maoist violence may no longer even have the strength to take its final breath. We are moving towards eliminating it completely. In areas where Naxalites once fired their guns, where the land was once stained with blood, today, in those very Naxal-affected regions and areas, the Tricolour of development, trust and endeavour is flying high.

Bank Accounts → UPI & Global Fintech Dominance

2015 - Even after sixty years of independence... 40% of the people of the country were without a bank account... the doors of the banks were not open for the poor.

2025 - Our own UPI platform is surprising the world today... India alone is doing 50% of the real-time transactions through UPI.

2026 - We have already demonstrated our capabilities through UPI and digital public infrastructure. We have made the world aware of our strength. Now Bharat must take its digital public technologies to every corner of the world.

Dignity for women to Women-led Reservation

2014 - We are living in the 21st century. Has it ever pained us that our mothers and sisters have to defecate in the open? Is the dignity of women not our collective responsibility? The poor women-folk of the village wait for the night; until darkness descends, they can't go out to defecate... Can't we just make arrangements for toilets for the dignity of our mothers and sisters?

2018 - I declare with pride the grant of Permanent Commission for the appointment of women officers in the Short Service Commission of Indian Armed Forces.

2026 - Let us step forward to uphold their dignity and ensure that our mothers and sisters secure 33% representation in the Legislative Assemblies and the Lok Sabha as soon as possible, so they may contribute to shaping India's policies. It is the need of the hour, and I once again urge all the political parties to come and join in the cause.

Putting Farmers First

2014 - But, please tell me why our farmers commit suicide? A farmer takes a loan from the moneylender, but fails to repay his loans. He takes a loan for the wedding of his daughter, but fails to repay. He will have to suffer hardships during his whole life. He chooses to commit suicide. Who will save the poor families of such farmers?

2018 - Economists, farmer organisations, farmers as well as political parties had been demanding that farmers should get an MSP which is one and a half times their investment. The matter was debated for years, files moved to and fro, but was stuck. Finally, we took the decision. We took a bold decision of giving the farmers the MSP, which is one and a half times their investment.

2025 - Last year, the farmers of my country broke all previous records in the production of grains... Agro products worth 4 lakh crore rupees have been exported.

2026 - Our farmers now have access to global markets. Because

of FTAs, we are getting access to a very large market... We have to move from the farm to the export market. Whether it is our traditional cuisine, our millets, our spices, our fruits or our flowers... today, due to this FTA, the possibility of export of our shrimp has increased a lot.

Start-up India

2015 - I have to provide strength to start-ups and, therefore, I resolve that in the coming days "Start-up India" and "Stand-up India" will be there.

2016 - There should not be any district, any block in Hindustan, where start-ups are not initiated in the coming days. India can dream that it will become number one in the world of start-ups. Today we are at that position.

2026 - We have opened up numerous avenues; we have opened up the startup sector. You must have seen that private startups in Bharat, led by young people with an average age of 28, launched their satellites and rockets, succeeding in their very first trial. They have accomplished something truly remarkable.

Manufacturing/Technology Self-Reliance

2014 - ...from electrical to electronics, 'Come, Make in India', from automobiles to agro value addition 'Come, Make in India', paper or plastic, 'Come, Make in India', satellite or submarine 'Come, Make in India'.

2025 - ...by the end of this very year, 'Made in India' chip, manufactured in Bharat by the people of Bharat, will be available in the market.

From operating systems to cyber security, from deep tech to artificial intelligence, everything should be our own, on which the strength of our own people is concentrated; we should introduce the power of their capabilities to the world.

2026 - We must significantly advance the manufacturing sector; alongside boosting production, we need to manufacture everything from small components to large-scale products. The entire value chain should be ours, and we should move ahead with it. We need components as well as complete manufacturing; we need complete products

Briefs

Hry: Hooda condemns Hansi, Ambala clashes



CHANDIGARH: Former Haryana Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda on Sunday condemned the lathi-charge and clashes in Hansi and Ambala, accusing the BJP government of failing to handle law-and-order issues. He said dialogue, not force, was the way forward. Hooda also announced a protest by Congress on August 19 seeking regularisation of Kaushal workers. He demanded guest teachers be regularised and urged dialogue with protesting farmers.

NFR celebrates I-Day



MALIGAON: North-east Frontier Railway (NFR) on Saturday celebrated the 80th Independence Day with patriotic fervour across its jurisdiction. At the main event at NFRSA Complex, General Manager Chetan Kumar Shrivastava hoisted the National Flag and paid tribute to freedom fighters and soldiers. He also acknowledged railway personnel for their round-the-clock service. On the occasion, 25 employees received Karmveer Puraskar with citations and cash rewards. The GM also inaugurated renovated and newly constructed facilities at Netaji Vidyapeeth Railway Higher Secondary School and the extended Casualty Building of Central Hospital, Maligaon.

I-Day: RCF GM highlights achievements



KAPURTHALA: The 80th Independence Day was celebrated with patriotic fervour at Maharaja Ranjit Singh Stadium, Rail Coach Factory (RCF), Kapurthala. RCF General Manager Ajay Nandan unfurled the National Flag, followed by the National Song, National Anthem and a parade by RPF, NCC, St John Ambulance Brigade and Bharat Scouts & Guides. Nandan highlighted RCF's record coach production, Vande Bharat coaches and exports to Bangladesh Railways. A cultural programme was also organised.

PROTEST ENTERS 23RD DAY

J'khand exam stir: Students burn effigies of Rahul Gandhi, CM Soren

MPOST BUREAU
Ranchi, August 16

Students protesting against alleged irregularities in Jharkhand's recruitment exams burnt the effigies of Chief Minister Hemant Soren, Rahul Gandhi and RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav here on Sunday, accusing the JMM-Congress alliance of "failing to take concrete action" on their demands. As the stir entered its 23rd day, the agitators took out a torchlight procession from the protest site of Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium to the Albert Ekka chowk, where they burnt the effigies.

They accused the ruling alliance of playing politics over their issues and announced they would gherao the chief minister's residence on August 20, demanding his resignation. Film and TV actor Kunickaa Sadanand met with the protesters at the stadium and spoke to Sabita Kumari, one of the six agitators who have been on a hunger strike for over two weeks now. She said the protesters had legitimate demands. A day earlier, the protesters had demanded the Congress withdraw support from the ruling coalition since the chief minister "was not listen-



Students burn effigies during a protest over alleged irregularities in the JPSC and JSSC exams in Ranchi on Sunday

ing to him". On Sunday, Leader of Opposition in the Jharkhand Assembly, Babul Marandi said, "Chief Minister Hemant Soren should accept the demands of the agitating students." Key demands of the JPSC-JSSC Reforms Manch, a prominent students' body spearheading the protest, include cancelling the 14th JPSC, a CBI probe into all examinations, making the probe report public and action against the guilty. The students are also

demanding the revocation of the suspension of a finance department section officer and whistleblower, Santosh Kumar Mastana, and withdrawal of cases filed against him. Marandi said, "The students have been demanding a CBI probe into the irregularities, and I think the government should order it. Why does the government fear this? If the government remains adamant, they are compelling the youth and students to take to the streets." About the students'

call to picket the chief minister's residence, the BJP leader said the party "extends its moral support to their agitation as they have been protesting peacefully for over three weeks". The state Congress' media in-charge, Rakesh Sinha, in a statement, said, "The Pradesh Congress will hold a meeting on August 18. The issue of reforms in the recruitment examinations conducted by Jharkhand Public Service Commission and Jharkhand Staff

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The agitators took out a torchlight procession from the protest site
- » They accused the ruling alliance of playing politics over their issues
- » They announced they would gherao the CM's residence on August 20

Selection Commission will be discussed. Any attempt to harm the future of Jharkhand's youth will not be tolerated." The Congress will strongly raise the students' voice to ensure transparency, impartiality, and a time-bound process in the recruitment examinations, he said. JPSC-JSSC Reforms Manch leader Ravindra Paswan said, "We will gherao the chief minister's residence on August 20. We seek his resignation as both the JMM and the Congress are playing politics with us. We also demand that Rahul Gandhi withdraw support from the JMM-led coalition if the CM is not listening to him." The protesters said they would not withdraw the demonstration until the government addresses their demands.

Sukhu assures HP youth of fair, merit-based govt recruitments

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Shimla, August 16

Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu on Saturday assured the state's youth of transparent and merit-based recruitment to government jobs, saying ensuring fairness in employment was a top priority of his government. Addressing the 80th Independence Day function at Barsar in Hamirpur district, Sukhu made a special appeal to Gen Z and said thousands of young people had been employed in the government sector. He claimed that no recruitment examination had witnessed a paper leak under the Congress government, contrasting it with the previous BJP regime, during which he alleged irregularities in police recruitment and Staff Selection Commission examinations. Sukhu said strict action had been taken against those involved in recruit-

I-DAY SPEECH

- » Sukhu said strict action had been taken against those involved in recruitment malpractices
- » He announced 100 new CBSE schools from next session
- » The CM also announced an additional Rs 20,000 towards salary arrears for Class IV employees this month

ment malpractices. He announced several measures, including an additional Rs 20,000 towards salary arrears for Class IV employees this month. Class III pensioners and family pensioners who retired between 2016 and 2021 will receive 35 per cent of their pension arrears, while Class I and II pensioners will receive 15 per cent. The government will spend Rs 281 crore on these payments. The CM announced 100 new CBSE schools from the next academic session and said doctors due to retire this month would continue in service until March 31, 2027. The monthly incen-

Odisha: Over 2.37L evacuated as heavy rainfall continues

CM to visit flood-hit areas today



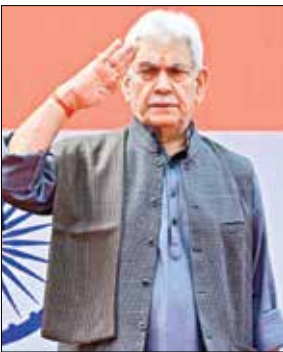
Villagers stand in knee-deep floodwater in Jajpur

MPOST BUREAU
Bhubaneswar, August 16

Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi is scheduled to visit flood-hit Bhadrak and Jajpur districts on Monday as the state remains on high alert following an IMD forecast of extremely heavy rain in the wake of the formation of a fresh low-pressure area over the Bay of Bengal. The state has evacuated more than 2.37 lakh people to safety as heavy rain continued for the second day, worsening the situation in several flood-hit northern districts, an official said. Taking to X, Majhi said the government was closely monitoring the situation and that local administrations were carrying out rescue and relief operations. "Ensuring swift assistance reaches the affected people and their safety

is our topmost priority. Tomorrow morning, I will visit the flood-affected areas to directly assess the situation. Please follow the administration's directives and stay safe; the government is always with you," he said. Majhi said three senior officers had been assigned to oversee rescue and relief operations in Balasore, Bhadrak and Jajpur, while the Special Relief Commissioner was coordinating with district administrations. Chief Secretary Anu Garg, who reviewed the situation following the IMD forecast, said leave of all government employees had been cancelled and those on leave were asked to report for duty immediately. "We have asked the district collectors to remain on high alert as the IMD has forecast very heavy rain for three days from August 16 to 18."

I-Day: L-G calls for collective efforts to build prosperous J&K



MPOST BUREAU
Srinagar, August 16

Jammu and Kashmir Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha on Saturday hoisted the National Flag at Lok Bhavan on the occasion of the 80th Independence Day, with a ceremonial police contingent presenting the National Salute. Paying tribute to freedom fighters, Sinha recalled their sacrifices and also mourned civilians who lost their lives in natural calamities this year. He called for collective efforts to build a peaceful and prosperous Jammu Kashmir and a strong nation. Sinha stressed the need for inclusive and balanced growth, women's economic empowerment, youth employment and environmental sustainability. He highlighted initiatives to restore heritage sites, ancient monuments and undertake afforestation drives. He urged citizens to contribute to building a self-reliant Jammu Kashmir and achieving the vision of Viksit Bharat by 2047, while stressing transparency and accountability in governance. The Lieutenant Governor congratulated J&K Police and CAPF personnel who received gallantry medals and praised sportspersons for their achievements. He called upon citizens to serve the nation with greater sincerity and dedication.

Rlys steps up measures to ensure safe drinking water Initiative follows observations made in CAG report on drinking water quality

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, August 16

Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw on Sunday ordered immediate corrective measures to ensure safe drinking water at railway stations across the country, following a Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) report that flagged the presence of harmful bacteria, such as E.coli, in water coolers at several stations. Vaishnaw, along with senior officials, conducted a daylong review and ordered several measures, including the installation of water-filtration systems, replacement of water tanks and regular testing of water quality, according to a press note

KEY POINTS

- » Vaishnaw ordered immediate corrective measures to ensure safe drinking water at railway stations
- » The CAG audit of more than 512 stations made startling revelations about poor water quality and inadequate passenger amenities
- » A new 'tank-to-tap' water-filtration system will be installed at 20,000 locations, including water coolers
- » Other measures include replacing water tanks, strict compliance with regular water quality testing at source and outlet points, centralised monitoring and accountability,

and scheduled cleaning and maintenance of storage tanks



FILE PIC

issued by the railway ministry on Sunday. The CAG audit of more than 512 stations made startling revelations about poor water quality and inadequate passenger amenities. The CAG found that the railway ministry had framed several norms for passenger amenities at

stations. However, zones failed to comply with those, leading to widespread deficiencies in services, including the presence of E.coli in the

drinking water in water coolers and unhygienic conditions in washrooms. Test results of drinking water samples collected from platform taps at 49 stations in eight zones during 2022-23 and 56 stations in nine zones during 2023-24 indicated the presence of Total coliform bacteria (including E.coli), the report stated. Following the deficiencies highlighted in the audit, the Railway Board sprang into action to take corrective measures. A new "tank-to-tap" water-filtration system will be installed at 20,000 locations, including water coolers. A comprehensive water-filtration-and-monitoring system will also be put in place at approxi-

mately 20,000 points across the railway network, a press note said. It added that other measures include replacing water tanks, strict compliance with regular water quality testing at source and outlet points, centralised monitoring and accountability, and scheduled cleaning and maintenance of storage tanks. "This is a top priority area and will be monitored directly at the Board level. Progress and water quality reports will be published periodically to ensure transparency," the ministry said. "This action is part of a larger drive to address all CAG observations and improve the overall travel experience," it added.

OVER PRIME MINISTER’S APPEAL TO OPPOSITION PARTIES

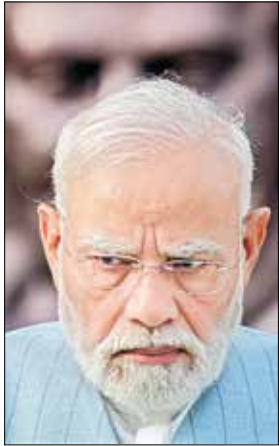
‘Agenda is Modi preservation, not women’s reservation’: Congress

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi August 16

The Congress on Sunday termed “drama” Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s appeal to Opposition parties to support the delimitation-linked Bill for implementing women’s reservation, and alleged that his single point agenda is “Modi preservation, not women’s reservation”.

Congress general secretary in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh questioned the intentions behind Prime Minister Modi’s appeal and said instead of “sermonising” from the Red Fort, he must implement the quota on the current strength of the Lok Sabha for 2029 polls.

Asked about the PM’s appeal to Opposition parties in his Independence Day speech, Ramesh said it is important to understand the chronology, as in 1993, the 73rd and 74th



PM Narendra Modi PTI

Constitutional Amendment Bills were passed, providing one-third reservation for women in Panchayats, Zilla Parishads, block Panchayats and municipalities.

It was Rajiv Gandhi who had done the ground work for that and he was instrumental in bringing this provision into the Constitution, Ramesh told news agency.

HIGHLIGHTS

» ‘Instead of sermonising from the Red Fort, PM must implement the quota on the current strength of the Lok Sabha for 2029 polls’

» Ramesh said the Congress and other Opposition parties have repeatedly called for women’s reservation implementation on the 543-member strength of the Lok Sabha

“In September 2023, the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023 was passed unanimously. It was Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge ji who had asserted that the women’s reservation in the Lok Sabha and state Assemblies should be implemented immediately,” he said.

Ramesh said the Congress and other Opposition parties have repeatedly

called for women’s reservation implementation on the 543-member strength of the Lok Sabha which means 182 seats for women be reserved.

Suddenly, at 11 pm on April 16, 2026, while the delimitation issue was being deliberated in Parliament, the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023 was notified.

He said the govt was only interested in linking women’s reservation with delimitation.

The govt has been attempting to get a “tainted two-thirds majority” but has not succeeded and the Constitution Amendment Bill involving delimitation could not be brought even in the Monsoon Session, he said.

“They don’t have a two-thirds majority and will never get it,” Ramesh said.

Instead of repeatedly “sermonising” from the Red Fort and doing this “drama”, the PM must

implement women’s reservation on the current strength of the Lok Sabha from the 2029 general election.

“The PM’s single-point agenda is ‘Modi preservation, not women’s reservation’,” Ramesh said.

His remarks come a day after Modi appealed to the Opposition parties to support the delimitation-linked women reservation Bill, saying the issue has been stuck in political ‘akhada’ (wrangling) for the last 40 years.

The Constitution amendment Bill, brought during the extended Budget Session, sought to implement 33 per cent reservation for women in legislatures in 2029 and to increase the number of Lok Sabha seats from 543 to 816.

A two-thirds majority was required to pass the proposed legislation in the Lower House. However it was defeated by the Opposition parties.

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Chittorgarh, August 16

Union Home minister Amit Shah on Sunday laid foundation stone for development projects worth Rs 5,755 crore and unveiled a 21-foot-tall statue of former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee while addressing the nation on his death anniversary.

Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma along with other officials were present on the occasion.

Amit Shah laid foundation stone for 944 projects worth Rs 5,755 crore in 15 districts of Rajasthan and said that a statue of former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee was erected in the state at an estimated cost of over Rs 1.50 crore as a tribute to the freedom fighter.

He said that Vajpayee was one of the true national leaders who believed in the principle of “Nation first” and served the nation with sincerity and dedication throughout his life.

Further while speak-



ing on the achievements of Vajpayee as Prime Minister, he said that he took India to the path of being a super power and took numerous initiatives for the development of the country like Golden Quadrilateral project for connecting the country through highways and linking it with rural roads, creation of Ministry of Tribal Administration etc.

He added that Prime

Minister Narendra Modi made tremendous efforts for the welfare of Scheduled Tribes by raising the ST Component budget from Rs 25,000 crore to Rs 1.25 lakh crore, declared National Tribal Welfare Day (Janjatiya Gaurav Diwas), organised museums related to tribal freedom fighters and opened 772 Eklavya Vidyalayas for the upliftment of tribal community.

Akhilesh questions border security, inflation, fuel prices

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Lucknow, August 16

Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday questioned the BJP government over the country’s border security, rising inflation, fuel prices and the closure of government primary schools, saying the issues required greater attention than delimitation.

“Today, the country needs security of its borders more than delimitation,” Yadav said while addressing the media after paying tribute to freedom fighter Rani Avantibai Lodhi on her birth anniversary in Hazratganj.

Yadav asked the BJP to state the geographical area of the country in 2014 and compare it with the present area.

He said questions were being raised over the security of the country’s borders.

He also targeted the government over inflation

and the blending of ethanol in petrol. “Inflation has increased in the country and E20 is being mixed in petrol. The government should tell us where these trees have been planted,” he said.

Yadav alleged that farmers were facing shortages and irregularities in the supply of fertilisers, including DAP. He also criticised the civic conditions in Lucknow, saying garbage was lying across the city.

Taking a swipe at the BJP’s tree plantation campaign, Yadav said, “BJP leaders say they have planted 300 crore trees. They should tell us where these trees have been planted.”

Yadav also attacked the Yogi Adityanath government over education and infrastructure.

He alleged that 500 primary schools had been closed in Gorakhpur and said the chief minister’s home district had itself witnessed the closure of the schools.

Mahua seeks Speaker’s intervention over circuit house row

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Kolkata, August 16

Trinamool Congress MP Mahua Moitra has written to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla seeking his urgent intervention after she was allegedly asked to vacate the Nadia Circuit House in Krishnanagar at 9.47 pm on August 14, claiming the incident violated her rights and raised serious questions over her safety.

Moitra said she had checked into the Circuit House at around 6.15 pm after returning to her constituency. At 9.47 pm, she received a call from the Additional District Magistrate asking her to vacate, saying the “order had come from the top”. At 10.52 pm, the administration sent her an order citing annual cleaning and maintenance.

Around 11 pm, Moitra said she heard shouting and realised a large crowd

had gathered outside the gates. In a video posted by her, people could be seen chanting “Jai Shree Ram” outside the Circuit House gate, while no visible security personnel were seen at the spot.

“The Circuit House is opposite the gates of bungalows of both the Superintendent of Police and the District Magistrate and is supposed to be a secure area where no crowds can gather,” she wrote.

She further said: “A woman MP, staying alone, being asked to vacate her rightful accommodation at 9.47 pm not only gravely violates her rights, but brings into question the safety and security accorded to women by the ruling dispensation.”

Moitra urged Birla to “urgently look into the matter” and ensure the dignity and security of women parliamentarians.

Ambernath clash: 2 BJP councillors booked

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Thane, August 16

Police have registered a case against at least two councillors of the BJP and other individuals following a violent clash between activists of the Maharashtra Navnirman Sena and the saffron party in Ambernath area of Thane district, based on a cross complaint, officials said on Sunday.

Earlier, the police had registered a case against MNS leaders following the incident.

The complaint against local BJP leaders was lodged by Suhas Ghag, who runs a pest control business. According to the FIR, Ghag went to meet a relative in Shivajinagar on the night of August 11, when a crowd had gathered due to an ongoing altercation.

While Ghag was transporting injured relatives and acquaintances in his vehicle to Shivajinagar police station, an aggressive group confronted them outside the police station gate at around 12:15 am on August 12, police said.

The complainant alleged that BJP corporators Abhijit Karanjule and Pawan Walekar, along with five identified persons and several others, who are unidentified, attacked him.

The FIR stated that Ghag was struck with an iron rod on his head and right hand, kicked and punched. The attackers also damaged his vehicle by throwing flower pots and breaking its windows, police said.

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 16

As Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s ‘dimagi Naxal’ remark in his Independence Day speech sparked a war of words between the Opposition and the BJP, Union minister Kiren Rijiju on Sunday said the PM was not referring to Opposition leaders but only to those who support Maoists and separatists and reject the Indian Constitution.

Addressing the nation on the 80th Independence Day, PM Modi on Saturday warned the country about ‘dimagi Naxals’ who have allegedly entrenched themselves in the system and continue to pose a threat to society by manipulating policies. He cautioned that “armed Naxals may have

NIMS GLOBAL LIMITED CIN: L27900DL1999PLC067808 Regd. Off.: UG-9, Plot No., 48, Hasanpur, I.P. Extn., Patparganj, Delhi-110092 Ph: 011-45261214 Email: info@nmslimited.in Web: www.nmslimited.in							
EXTRACT OF STANDALONE AND CONSOLIDATED UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED 30th JUNE, 2026							
S. No.	Particulars	STANDALONE (in Lakhs)			CONSOLIDATED (in Lakhs)		
		Quarter ended 30.06.2026 (UnAudited)	Quarter ended 30.06.2025 (UnAudited)	Year ended 31.03.2026 (Audited)	Quarter ended 30.06.2026 (UnAudited)	Quarter ended 30.06.2025 (UnAudited)	Year ended 31.03.2026 (Audited)
1	Total Revenue	131.91	96.64	1170.91	239.39	304.30	4328.49
2	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period (before tax, exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	5.29	11.99	35.95	8.89	14.74	105.10
3	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period before tax (after exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	5.29	11.99	35.95	8.89	14.74	105.10
4	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period after tax (after exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	4.04	8.87	17.26	6.83	10.91	71.79
5	Total comprehensive income for the period (Comprising Profit/(loss) for the period (after tax) and other Comprehensive income (after tax)	4.04	8.87	17.26	6.83	10.91	71.79
6	Equity Share Capital	300.56	300.56	300.56	300.56	300.56	300.56
7	Earnings Per Share (of Re.10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operation)	0.13	0.30	0.57	0.23	0.36	2.39
	Diluted:	0.13	0.30	0.57	0.23	0.36	2.39
NOTES: 1. The above financial results standalone and consolidated were reviewed and recommended by the audit committee and were thereafter approved by the Board of Directors of the company at its meeting held on 14.08.2026. A limited review of the above results has been carried out by the statutory auditors. 2. These financial results have been prepared in accordance with the recognition and measurement principles of Indian Accounting Standards ("Ind AS") prescribed under section 133 of The Companies Act, 2013 read with the relevant rules issued thereunder and the other accounting principles generally accepted in India, and in terms of Regulation 33 of the SEBI (LODR) Regulation 2015. 3. The company did not have any investor complaint pending as on Year ended 30.06.2026. 4. Previous quarter period figures have been regrouped / rearranged and rounded off wherever necessary, to make them comparable. 5. E.P.S. has been calculated in accordance with IND AS-33 issued by the ICAI. 6. Previous Year figures have been regrouped or recasted wherever necessary. 7. Significant Accounting Policies and Notes accompanying Ind AS Financial Statements The above is an extract of the detailed format of Audited Financial Results for the Quarter ended June 30, 2026, filed with the BSE under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the aforesaid Quarter ended June 30, 2026 Financial Results is available on the BSE's website and on the Company's website www.nmslimited.in and can also be accessed by scanning the given QR Code.							
For and on behalf of Board Directors of NIMS GLOBAL LIMITED Sd/- Dhananjay Gupta Chairperson/MO DIN: 09313879							
Place: New Delhi Date: 14 August, 2026							

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Ajay Kashyap S/o Babu Ram R/o B-46, Uday Vihar, Chander Vihar, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No. 403/2022 U/S 147/148/149/186/353/332 IPC & 3PDDP Act, PS Hari Nagar, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused **Ajay Kashyap** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Ajay Kashyap** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Ajay Kashyap of FIR No. 403/2022 U/S 147/148/149/186/353/332 IPC & 3PDDP Act, PS Hari Nagar, New Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **17.09.2026**.

By Order,
Ms. Vasundhara Azad
Judicial Magistrate First Class-11 (West)
West Dist., Court No.146, 1st Floor
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi
DP/11436/DWD/2026(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Surender S/o Pal Singh R/o Jhuggi No. E-3828, JJ Colony, Bawana, Delhi & Rohit @ Montu S/o Mohan R/o H. No. E-1471, JJ Colony, Bawana, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No. 313/2021 U/S 392/411/34 IPC, PS Narela Industrial Area, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused **Surender & Rohit @ Montu** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Surender & Rohit @ Montu** has absconded (or is concealing themselves to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Surender & Rohit @ Montu of FIR No. 313/2021 U/S 392/411/34 IPC, PS Narela Industrial Area, Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **14.09.2026**.

By Order,
Sh. Sahil Gupta
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07
Room No. 06, Mound Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi
DP/11454/ON/2026(Court Matter)

News at a glance

Iranian parliament advances bill to curb foreign influence

DUBAI: Iran's parliament approved on Sunday the general principles of a bill that would criminalise interviews and other communications with media deemed hostile to the Islamic Republic, including U.S. or Israeli media and outlets financed by either country, Iran's Shargh newspaper reported.

Osman Salari, a member of parliament's judicial and legal commission, said the individual provisions of the bill, which is aimed at countering foreign intelligence influence, have yet to be debated and approved.

Pope Leo calls for an end to West Bank violence

CASTEL GANDOLFO: Pope Leo called on Sunday for an end to violence against Palestinians in the occupied West Bank, amid a surge of attacks by militant settlers and a siege in the territory's village of Qusra.

Israeli settlers encircled houses after cutting off water and electricity, in what rights groups have said is a concerted effort to seize more land, and further eat into territory. "I renew my appeal for an end to the repeated violence against the Palestinian civilian population in the West Bank," the Pope said.

Bus crash in Hungary kills 12 people, injures at least 10

BUDAPEST: A passenger bus travelling on a highway in Hungary early Sunday went off the road and into a ditch where it overturned, killing 12 and injuring others, police said.

The bus, which was carrying a group of Polish tourists, was travelling on eastbound lanes near the town of Mezokeresztes when it overturned on the M3 motorway around 140 kilometres east of Hungary's capital, Budapest, at around 1 am on Sunday. In a statement, police said it was likely that the driver fell asleep, causing the accident.



Brazilian President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva, (second left), holds a Brazilian flag ahead of polls in October

AP/PTI

AT LEAST 6 PEOPLE KILLED SO FAR

Ukraine hitsMoscow in mass drone attack

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Moscow, August 16

Ukraine launched hundreds of drones across Russia on Sunday, killing at least six people in one of Kyiv's largest aerial attacks of the war.

Kyiv has stepped up its attacks on Russia this year, with long-range missiles and swarms of drones targeting military industries and energy facilities.

It has also increasingly pummelled giant Wildberries depots, burning billions of dollars' worth of merchandise belonging to the Russian online retail giant.

Those attacks have brought the war home to the Russian public nearly 4½ years into Moscow's full-scale invasion of Ukraine.

Meanwhile, Ukraine also came under Russian attack, with drone strikes



A drone attack targeted three towns in Russia's Rostov region

destroying homes and torching Kyiv's landmark book market.

Russia's Ministry of Defence said it had destroyed 822 Ukrainian drones overnight. Some 600 drones were detected headed toward the Russian capital, Moscow Mayor Sergei Sobyanin said, with a third of those destroyed over the Moscow region itself.

An 83-year-old man was killed after a Ukrainian drone hit a private home in the Moscow region, local

HIGHLIGHTS

» Kyiv has stepped up its attacks on Russia this year, with long-range missiles and swarms of drones targeting military industries and energy facilities

» An 83-year-old man was killed after a Ukrainian drone hit a private home in the Moscow region, local Gov. Andrey Vorobyov says

Gov. Andrey Vorobyov said. He also confirmed that a Ukrainian attack had sparked a blaze at a Wildberries warehouse in the town of Podolsk.

A drone attack targeted three towns in Russia's southwestern Rostov region, killing five people, local Gov. Yuri Slyusar said.

Wildfires ravage protected forest twice size of Wales since 2001: Study

The study draws on high-resolution satellite data

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
London, August 16

Over four million hectares of protected tropical forest - an area twice the size of Wales - has been destroyed by wildfires since 2001, with nearly a third of all 24-year losses occurring in 2024 alone, a detailed global assessment has found.

The annual area burned inside the protected areas has been roughly nine times higher since 2016 compared to previous years and Brazil alone accounted for almost two-thirds of global losses, the study has found.

Accelerating at an alarming rate, this destruction threatens sanctuaries once thought safe, according to a new University of Sheffield study, for which the researchers combined satellite wildfire



THE VAST MAJORITY OF THE DESTRUCTION – AROUND 89 PER CENT – OCCURRED IN THE TROPICAL AMERICAS, PARTICULARLY IN BRAZIL

data with maps of more than 9,700 protected areas across the tropics, tracking forest losses between 2001 and 2024.

The comparative data showed that more than four million hectares of

protected tropical forest have been lost to wildfires since 2001.

This is roughly equal to the size of the Indian state of Haryana (4.42 million hectares).

The study, published in the journal Global Change Biology last week, is the first to assess in detail how much protected tropical forest has been lost to wildfires worldwide, and whether protected status actually reduces the risk of forests burning, a statement from the university said on Friday.

The vast majority of the destruction - around 89 per cent - occurred in the tropical Americas, particularly in Brazil, which alone accounted for almost two-thirds of global losses. Bolivia and Indonesia also recorded substantial losses, it said.

BUSINESS

THE GOVT SEEKS TO BUILD A DOMESTIC SUPPLY BUFFER

Govt sets LPG output targets for refiners, Reliance gets largest quota

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 16

The government has for the first time fixed maximum cooking gas LPG production targets for individual public- and private-sector refineries and upstream companies, as it seeks to build a domestic supply buffer after the West Asia conflict exposed the country's vulnerability to disruptions in imported cooking gas.

The Petroleum and Natural Gas Ministry, in an order issued on August 13, has specified maximum LPG production levels for 21 refineries and upstream companies, with combined production poten-

tial set at 63,810 tonnes a day - more than double the domestic LPG output in the fiscal year ended March 31, 2026 and about 70 per cent of the country's daily consumption.

The production limits will kick in whenever there is a supply constraint. The lion's share of the planned output has been set from Reliance Industries Ltd's older refinery, which would have to produce up to 18,000 tonnes a day of LPG, according to the order.

India consumed 33.2 million tonnes of LPG in the 2025-26 fiscal year (about 91,000 tonnes per day). Of this, 13.1 million tonnes a year was



produced locally (about 35,900 tonnes a day) while the remaining 21.3 million tonnes per annum (about 58,400 tonnes a day) was imported.

This high import dependence of over 64 per cent left the country exposed when the start of the Iran war effectively shut the Strait of Hormuz, the narrow sealane through which India got

90 per cent of its imports from nations like Saudi Arabia.

With supplies impacted, the government in March ordered refineries to divert streams used for petrochemicals production to maximise LPG output.

It also initially stopped sales to industrial and commercial users and thereafter gradually scaled it up. For domestic households, periodicity of booking a refill was increased, and they were encouraged to shift to piped natural gas, whose supplies were not so severely impacted due to the war.

Domestic production

was ramped up to about 55,000 tonnes a day at the height of the crisis, but the emergency orders asking refiners to maximise output were gradually withdrawn after supplies eased from mid-June.

The new order goes further than the emergency one issued during the West Asia crisis by creating facility-wise production benchmarks and requiring refiners and upstream companies to maintain adequate infrastructure for LPG storage, evacuation and transportation. Companies must also pursue technically and economically feasible upgrades to maximise output.

ONGC gets US licence to resume full operations in Venezuela

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 16

State-owned Oil and Natural Gas Corp (ONGC) has secured a licence from the US Treasury's Office of Foreign Assets Control (OFAC), allowing it to resume full operations in Venezuela after years of limiting activity because of sanctions-related risks, a senior company official said.

The US approval removes a key hurdle for ONGC's Venezuelan investments and could pave the way for the state-run explorer to expand production, sign new agreements and take over operatorship of some projects from Venezuela's state oil company PDVSA, Anupam Agarwal, director-finance at ONGC, said at an investor call post first quarter earnings announcement.

"Now we have full free-



dom to work on the Venezuela project because earlier we were restricting our operations there because of the sanction-related risks. Those risks are behind us," Agarwal said.

ONGC Videsh Ltd, the company's overseas investment arm, holds a 40 per cent interest in the San Cristobal oil project, while the remaining is with Venezuela's Petroleos de Venezuela S.A. (PDVSA).

It holds another 11 per cent stake in the Carabobo project, which is under development.

An OFAC license would enable the company to manage the finances of its Venezuelan projects and help it recover a pending dividend of more than \$500 million.

ONGC is already in talks with Venezuelan authorities and its joint-venture partners over its interests in two projects - San Cristobal and Carabobo - and expects positive developments soon, including new agreements and a possible transfer of operatorship from PDVSA, he said.

The licence is significant for ONGC because US sanctions on Venezuela's oil sector have for years complicated financial transactions, investment and operations involving Venezuelan crude and energy assets. The company had therefore curtailed activity despite its longstanding presence in the country.

INDEPENDENCE DAY CELEBRATIONS



DVC celebrated its 80th Independence Day at its Headquarters, featuring a rendition of Vande Mataram marking its 150 years, flag hoisting by Chairman Rajesh Pandey & National Anthem sung by DVC employees. Awards were presented to employees for organisational excellence & to their wards for exemplary academic achievements.



Bank of Baroda (BoB) celebrated 80th Independence Day at its Corporate Office in Mumbai. The celebrations commenced with unfurling of National Flag by Dr. Debaddatta Chand, MD & CEO, in presence of Bank's Executive Directors & senior leadership, followed by singing of the National Anthem. Chand also felicitated Indian Navy officers during Independence Day celebrations.



The 80th Independence Day was celebrated with great enthusiasm and patriotic fervour at Modern Coach Factory (MCF), Rae Bareilly with the singing of the National Song 'Vande Mataram'. Chief Guest Raman Krishnan, General Manager, MCF, unfurled the National Flag and took the salute of the parade.



Punjab State Power Corporation Limited (PSPCL) and Punjab State Transmission Corporation Limited (PSTCL) celebrated Independence Day with patriotic fervour and enthusiasm. On the occasion, CMD Dr. Basant Garg felicitated officers and employees in recognition of their dedicated services and responsibilities being discharged by them.

FOR RATE ADJUSTMENTS IN GOVT CONTRACTS

Finance Ministry nudges all ministries to switch to PPI

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 16

The Finance Ministry has nudged all ministries and departments to move to Producer Price Index (PPI), from the current Wholesale Price Index (WPI), for rate escalation and adjustment clauses in future government procurement contracts.

The Department of Expenditure, in a communication to all ministries and departments, said that PPI is a more internationally accepted index compared to WPI used in government contracts to define price escalation.

For the first time, the Commerce Ministry has started issuing monthly PPI data for both goods and services since June to better reflect price movement at the producer's level, thus paving the way for phasing out wholesale price inflation numbers in the next five years.

"Ministries/Departments are encouraged to adopt Producer Price Index (PPI) in place of Wholesale Price Index (WPI) in all price escalation clauses of future con-



'PPI IS A MORE INTERNATIONALLY ACCEPTED INDEX COMPARED TO WPI USED IN GOVERNMENT CONTRACTS TO DEFINE PRICE ESCALATION'

tracts, once PPI becomes available," the expenditure department said in an office memorandum dated July 13, which was sent to all ministries.

The price escalation or rate variation clause in government contracts allows payments to be adjusted in line with changes in the cost of key inputs, such as materials, labour and fuel, during the execution of a project. It helps distribute the impact of inflation between the government and the contractor.

The launch of monthly

PPI data is in line with practices adopted by advanced economies and follows the recommendations of the International Monetary Fund (IMF), which stressed that India needs to transition from WPI to PPI.

The output (goods) PPI cover all representative goods transacted in the economy. Manufactured items have the highest 69.93 per cent weight in output PPI (goods), followed by agriculture, forestry and fishing (22.16 per cent), electricity (4.49 per cent), and mining and

KEY POINTS

- » The Commerce Ministry has started issuing monthly PPI data for both goods and services since June to better reflect price movement at the producer's level
- » The price escalation or rate variation clause in government contracts allows payments to be adjusted in line with changes in the cost of key inputs
- » It helps distribute the impact of inflation between the government and the contractor

quarrying (3.42 per cent).

Seven services -- banking, securities transaction, insurance, management of pension funds, railways, air (passenger), and telecom -- have been covered in the first phase of Service PPI, while remaining services will be covered in the next phase, the Commerce and Industry Ministry had said while launching the PPI data in June.

In the case of Service PPI, no weights are being assigned, since the seven services does not cover the entire service sector.

MMDR Amendment Bill aims to bring long-term stability to major minerals sector

Ministry of Mines said the amendment does not take away any rights of states over land & minerals or their power to levy taxes on minerals

ANI NEWS
New Delhi, August 16

The Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, passed by both Houses of Parliament on August 13, aims to bring greater certainty and stability to India's major minerals sector by creating a more predictable fiscal regime and encouraging investment in domestic mining, the Ministry of Mines said in a press release.

The Ministry said the amendment does not take away any rights of states over land and minerals or their power to levy taxes on minerals.

Around 90 per cent of the taxes and statutory payments from mining currently accrue to states, and this arrangement will continue under the amended framework.

The amendment will also not affect states' powers to regulate and tax minor minerals.

The government said the changes are intended to provide certainty and predictability in the fiscal regime, which could give a boost to investment in



mining and support the objectives of Aatmanirbhar Bharat and the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047.

The ministry highlighted the importance of domestic mineral production, noting that minerals are critical for infrastructure, manufacturing, energy security and broader economic development.

India imported minerals worth Rs 10.12 lakh crore in FY26, and the government said steep and unbalanced taxation could make domestic minerals less competitive, prompting greater reliance on imports and increasing the burden on the exchequer.

States currently impose

around 14 types of taxes, charges, fees and other levies on mining operations, including royalty, auction premium, dead rent, contributions to the District Mineral Foundation, GST and transit fees.

Between FY16 and FY26, major mining states received more than Rs 5 lakh crore from mining, while the Centre's revenue stood at Rs 82,000 crore, according to the ministry. This distribution of revenue, it said, will remain unchanged following the amendment.

The ministry also pointed to auction premiums as a major source of additional state revenue since the auction

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Around 90% of the taxes & statutory payments from mining accrue to states
- » Between FY16 & FY26, major mining states received over Rs 5 lakh crore from mining, while the Centre's revenue stood at Rs 82,000 crore
- » Between FY21 and FY26, major mining states collected more than Rs 96,000 crore in auction premiums

regime was introduced in 2015. Between FY21 and FY26, major mining states collected more than Rs 96,000 crore in auction premiums, over and above revenues from royalty, DMF and GST.

Given that mineral resources are finite and geographically concentrated in a limited number of states, the ministry said their management requires a cohesive national approach. It argued that uneven state-level taxation can raise domestic costs, weaken the competitiveness of locally available minerals and encourage imports despite the availability of domestic resources.

Gold and silver prices likely to remain positive next week

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, August 16

Gold and silver prices are expected to remain positive next week, although elevated volatility is likely to persist amid developments in West Asia and key global economic data, analysts said.

Market participants will track US housing and trade data, inflation figures from the UK, EU, and Japan, as well as China's economic indicators for cues on industrial metals.

On the domestic front, gold futures for October delivery climbed Rs 2,686, or nearly 2 per cent, last week to Rs 1.54 lakh/10 grams on the MCX. MCX silver for September contract rose Rs 4,458, or 1.9 per cent to Rs 2.35 lakh/kg.

In the international markets, Comex gold futures for December delivery rose \$37.6, or nearly 1 per cent, last week to \$4,437.3 per ounce. Silver went up \$1.61, or 2.5 per cent, to \$65.11 an ounce in New York.

PM GatiShakti: 396 infra projects of ₹18.66 lakh cr proposed for approval

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, August 16

As many as 396 infrastructure projects of different ministries, including roads and railways, worth Rs 18.66 lakh crore have been recommended for approval under the PM GatiShakti initiative, according to government data.

These projects have been recommended by the Network Planning Group (NPG) constituted under the PM GatiShakti initiative launched on October

13, 2021.

"As on date, 396 infrastructure projects with total estimated cost of about Rs 18.66 lakh crore have been evaluated through the NPG mechanism. Of these, 396 projects, 256 projects have been sanctioned -- out of which, 198 projects are under implementation," the data showed.

The initiative was launched to develop an integrated infrastructure to reduce logistics costs. All logistics and connectivity infrastructure proj-

ects, entailing investments of over Rs 500 crore are routed through the NPG.

Addressing the country from the ramparts of the Red Fort on the 80th Independence Day on August 15, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said under Gati Shakti, "we must focus on seamless and fast connectivity across the country".

Commenting on the initiative, experts said Gati Shakti must connect not only cities and ports, but the entire journey from factory gate to consumer doorstep.

Independence Day sales push e-comm order volumes up 31%

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, August 16

India's e-commerce sector recorded a 31 per cent year-on-year growth in order volumes during the 2026 Independence Day sale period, according to data by e-commerce enablement platform Unicommerce.

The insights, derived from order items processed on the company's Uniware platform between August 6 and 14, also revealed a 30

per cent rise in gross merchandise value (GMV), compared to the same period in 2025.

According to the report, the fashion and accessories segment captured the highest share of total order volumes, with apparel emerging as the leading category. This was closely followed by beauty, wellness, and personal care segment, where skincare and hygiene products dominated consumer interest.

'Six food cos fix misleading claims after crackdown'

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, August 16

Food regulator FSSAI on Sunday said six companies have taken corrective actions like withdrawal of misleading labels and trade marks, following the notices issued to these companies for violations of law.

In a social media post, FSSAI informed that six Food Business Operators

(FBOs) have taken prompt corrective actions following notices from the regulator.

Giving details, the FSSAI said Livyor Ventures Pvt Ltd has withdrawn misleading claim of 'vegan & healthy'.

The company has submitted its reply with reference to regarding the misleading claims made on the label of the product "Livyroasted Edamame Beans". In its reply, the FBO

has stated that the claims "vegan" and "healthy" were inadvertently printed on the product label due to a lack of awareness of the applicable regulatory requirements.

"The FBO has expressed regret for the lapse, apologised for the violation, and assured that such non-compliance will not be repeated in the future," the regulator said. Further, the FBO has

informed that it has initiated the process of revising the product labels. The company is destroying the existing packaging material bearing the non-compliant claims to ensure that it is not used in the future.

Similarly, Honest Innovations For You Pvt Ltd and HelioStone Specialties Pvt Ltd have changed their misleading trade mark.

Rajasthan Agro and

General Industries has complied with the notice and removed/deleted all misleading claims and has stopped utilising the PPM.

Iota Nanotechnology Pvt Ltd has removed misleading claims from the label and stopped production of non-standardised water.

Panchamurtha Industries Pvt Ltd has delisted the product (electrolyte drink) from its website.

CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE

REC Power Development and Consultancy Limited (RECPDCL) handed over Vizag Power Transmission Limited, the project-specific Special Purpose Vehicle (SPV), to Adani Energy Solutions Limited, on August 14, 2026. The SPV was handed over by Rajkumar Sonkar, HoD (CS), RECPDCL to Shashank Sharma, CBDO, Adani Energy Solutions Ltd, in the presence of Ratnesh Kumar, GM (Engg).

DRI busts ₹2,500 cr customs duty fraud in areca nut imports

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, August 16

DRI officers have dismantled a network involved in importing South-East Asian areca nuts into India by falsely declaring them as Bangladeshi origin and fraudulently availing concessional duty benefits under the South Asian Free Trade Area (SAFTA).

The finance ministry, in a statement, said an investigation by the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) has so far revealed a potential revenue loss of more than Rs 2,500 crore through illegal imports of areca nuts. Nine persons have been arrested in connection with the case.

The import of areca nuts into India attracts a Basic Customs Duty (BCD) of 100 per cent. However, eligible imports of areca nuts made under the SAFTA agreement are fully exempt from customs duty. The areca nuts originating from Bangladesh are entitled to exemption under SAFTA if imports meet the prescribed Rules of Origin criterion.

Intelligence gathered and developed by DRI indicated that certain syndicates were fraudulently claiming SAFTA benefits

on a very large scale on imports of areca nuts.

"While they were importing areca nuts originating and sourced from Indonesia, Thailand, Malaysia and other South-East Asian countries, they were mis-declaring the country of origin of areca nuts imported into India as Bangladesh," the ministry said.

Thereafter, simultaneous searches were conducted at multiple premises linked to importers, customs brokers and IEC holders in Kolkata and Visakhapatnam.

Several incriminating documents and substantial evidences establishing the South-East Asian origin of areca nuts were recovered.

DRI officers also recovered and seized around Rs 75 lakh in cash, believed to be sale proceeds of illegally-imported goods and seized 160 MT of areca nuts. "The investigations so far have revealed huge scale of fraudulent imports of areca nuts in which exchequer has been duped of customs duty in excess of Rs 2,500 crore in recent years," the ministry said, adding that the customs broker's licence has been suspended and nine persons have been arrested.

INDEPENDENCE DAY CELEBRATIONS

NMDC celebrated 80th Independence Day in presence of Amitava Mukherjee, CMD and Directors Vinay Kumar, Joydeep Dasgupta, Krishna Kumar Thakur, Anurag Kapil & Vivek Nishant Nath, along with CVO C Neelakanta Reddy.

Deepak Gupta, CMD, GAIL, hoisted the National Flag at GAIL Corporate Office, New Delhi, on the occasion of Independence Day, in presence of Directors Ayush Gupta, Sanjay Kumar, Rajeev Kumar Singhal, SK Sinha & Rajnesh Singh, CVO.

Punjab National Bank celebrated the 80th Independence Day at its Dwarka Headquarters with PNB MD & CEO Ashok Chandra hoisting the National Flag and paying homage to Lala Lajpat Rai, freedom fighter and one of the founders of PNB.

NBCC (India) Ltd celebrated the 80th Independence Day at NBCC Bhawan, Lodhi Road, New Delhi with the hoisting of the National Flag, followed by the National Anthem and National Song, in the presence of Dr. K P Mahadevaswamy, CMD, NBCC, Functional Directors, CVO and other senior officers, and employees.

DESPITE SRI LANKAN BOWLERS' IMPROVED SHOW

Padikkal 167, Jurel's fifty carry team India to 460/9 on day two of 1st Test

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Galle, August 16

Devdutt Padikkal's sophisticated 167 was the centrepiece in India's strong 460 for nine at stumps despite the Sri Lankan spinners growing fangs on a truncated second day of the first Test here on Sunday.

Kuldeep Yadav (12) and Prasidh Krishna (1) were batting at close.

Rains of varying intensity and the resultant wet outfield delayed the start of the day's play until 2.35 pm, and the long break seemed to have rejuvenated the Lankans more.

The home bowlers produced better lines and lengths than day one, cutting down the scoring areas of Indian batters, who resumed from a far stronger 288 for two.

It was the perfect launching pad to be in a far healthier position, but the tourists lost seven wickets – some to the Lankan spinners' guile and some to their own indiscretions – for 172 runs.

Padikkal, who started from 131, brought up his maiden 150 in 215 balls when he pulled pacer Asitha Fernando for a boundary.

However, before the left-hander reached his landmark, India had lost the other overnight batter Rishabh Pant for 39.

Pant seemed impatient to stamp his authority over



Dhruv Jurel celebrates his half century on day two of the first Test match between India and Sri Lanka, in Galle on Sunday

KEY POINTS

- » India went to tea at 364 for five, and needed a few more runs to really pull away from Sri Lanka
- » KL Rahul, who had to retire on 77 because of cramps the previous day, walked in next but could only add four more runs to his overnight score

the bowlers, but the over-zealousness ended his stint, as a feeble loft off off-spinner Keshara Nuwantha was snaffled by a running-in Sonal Dinusha.

KL Rahul, who had to

retire on 77 because of cramps the previous day, walked in next but could only add four more runs to his overnight score.

Rahul failed to negotiate the turn and bounce from

Nuwantha, giving a simple catch to Nishan Madhushka at short leg.

Capturing two big wickets by giving away just 12 runs put a spring on Lankan bowlers' steps and the hosts added the big wicket of Padikkal at the stroke of tea to further boost their standing.

The left-hander was deceived on flight by left-arm spinner Prabath Jayasuriya and stumper Niroshan Dickwella did the rest.

However, the bigwigs

will be delighted to see the way Padikkal responded to the task of occupying a crucial slot like No. 3.

It has given them another option even when original resident Sai Sudharsan returns from his toe injury.

India went to tea at 364 for five, and needed a few more runs to really pull away from Sri Lanka.

Ravindra Jadeja was trapped leg before by Nuwantha immediately after the break, leaving India at 377 for six.

Indian women's hockey team holds China to 2-2 draw in WC

India will next play South Africa on August 18

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Amstelveen, August 16

The Indian women's hockey team dished out a valiant performance as it held Paris Olympics silver medallists China to a 2-2 draw to start its Hockey World Cup campaign on a high note here on Sunday.

In what was considered as their toughest match in Pool D, India dominated the opening quarter and prevented China from playing their natural game. By halftime, India were 2-1 ahead.

Had India been awarded penalty corner in the final quarter, the outcome could have been different. Navneet Kaur, who was in excellent form throughout the match, tried to penetrate the opposition circle in the final moments, but China thwarted her



Players of the Indian women's hockey team and China line up for their national anthems ahead of their opening Pool D match on Sunday

attempt.

After the match, Indian coach Sjoerd Marijne expressed his displeasure over India not being awarded a penalty corner.

"I dont know why that PC was not given," said Marijne.

Navneet (8th minute) and Deepika (26th) scored for India, while

Zhang Ying struck from a penalty stroke in the 14th minute before Ma Ning found the equalising goal for China, converting a penalty corner in the 39th minute.

India will next play South Africa on August 18. England defeated South Africa 4-0 in another match of the day.

SC Delhi storm into Durand Cup SFs

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Ranchi, August 16

SC Delhi produced a remarkable second-half comeback to defeat debutants FC Raengdai of Manipur 5-1 and storm into the semifinals of the Durand Cup football tournament here on Sunday.

After Chongtham Kishan Singh's (9th minute) stunning long-range strike had put Raengdai ahead in the first half, substitute Joseph Sunny's (57th, 67th) second-half brace turned the game

around. Rodriguinho (82nd), Juan Sebastian Pena (90+3) and Augustine Lalrochana (90+8) were the other SC Delhi goal scorers in the quarter-final match.

FC Raengdai made their intentions clear from the opening whistle, controlling possession, moving the ball patiently and pressing high.

SC Delhi, however, threatened on the counter in the seventh minute when captain Lamgoulen Semkholum delivered an excellent cross

from the right. Pena produced a fantastic leap to direct his header towards the far post, but the ball bounced over the crossbar.

Two minutes later, FC Raengdai took the lead in spectacular fashion. Chongtham Kishan Singh unleashed a bullet of a shot from around 20 metres that dipped late, struck the inside of the crossbar and bounced into the net, leaving SC Delhi goalkeeper Nora Fernandes with no chance.

FILM

Ranveer Singh starts shooting for survival thriller 'Pralay'

Also turns producer for the film starring actress Kalyani Priyadarshan

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 16

After delivering two back-to-back mega blockbusters with 'Dhurandhar' and 'Dhurandhar: The Revenge', which emerged as the highest-grossing film of all time, Bollywood actor Ranveer Singh has started shooting for his new survival thriller, 'Pralay'. The film went on floors in Mumbai. Jai Mehta, son of filmmaker Hansal Mehta, is the director of the film.

For those unaware, Jai, whose work on 'Scam 1992: The Harshad Mehta Story', which he co-directed with Hansal Mehta and 'Lootere' has earned widespread acclaim. And joining Ranveer on this mega spectacle is 'Lokah' breakout actress Kalyani Priyadarshan.

Interestingly, Ananya Birla's production house is backing the film. Adding to the excitement, Ranveer not only headlines the film but also serves as a producer on 'Pralay'. The film also has Hansal Mehta and Sahil Saigal as producers.

Set against the unmistakable pulse and land-



SET AGAINST THE LANDSCAPE OF MUMBAI, 'PRALAY' IS AN ORIGINAL STORY THAT SEEKS TO MARRY BREATHTAKING SPECTACLE WITH A DEEPLY HUMAN EMOTIONAL CORE

scape of Mumbai, 'Pralay' is an original story that seeks to marry breathtaking spectacle with a deeply human emotional core. The film is being shot at live locations in and around Mumbai.



'We haven't made the film for kids': Yash on 'Toxic'

The actor credits director Geetu Mohandas for pushing him to explore a different role as an actor



OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 16

Actor Yash made it clear that 'Toxic: A Fairy Tale for Grown-Ups' hasn't been conceived as children's entertainment. The trailer of the film has sparked criticism over its portrayal of women. In fact, the song 'Tabaahi' starring Yash and Kiara Advani also faced backlash over its intimate scenes. Yash pointed to the film's tagline, 'A Fairy Tale for Grown-Ups', as an important indication of the kind of story audiences are stepping into.

"From the time I have put the title, I have put a tagline under it. This is a fairy tale for grown-ups," he said. Clarifying the intended audience, the

“CHILDREN DON'T HAVE TO WATCH. THIS FILM IS NOT MADE FOR CHILDREN. ALL THE CHILDREN HAVE TO STAY AT HOME. THAT IS VERY CLEAR”

'KGF' actor said, "Children don't have to watch. This film is not made for children. All the children have to stay at home. That is very clear. We have not made it for kids."

Yash, who appeared on a TV show, also responded to the criticism surrounding the 'vulgarity' in the film. "Vulgarity is wrong. I haven't even kissed, as you may have noticed," he said. But the actor also said

that things need to be shot aesthetically to make it visually appealing.

The superstar also opened up about his experience of working with director Geetu Mohandas and credited her for pushing him to explore a different side of himself as an actor in 'Toxic', which releases on August 26. "Geetu comes across like she is strict, but she is very, very jovial. The way she creates the atmosphere for everybody on the set, I think she has pushed all of us. Especially for me, she has pushed me. She has made me learn lines in English," he said.

Emphasising the importance of trusting a director's vision, Yash added, "I think it is important for you to have faith in your director. I had that faith, so I think you have witnessed a different kind of Yash in this movie."